

MUTAGEN

The Rulebook

A tabletop roleplaying game about freelancers who rebuild their own bodies to survive a city that is rebuilding itself.

Version 0.2 · compiled from the chapter files · xenodorian.github.io/BeelzRPG

About This Book

This is the complete game in one document: every rule, the six Augment trees, the threat builder and roster, the starter mission, the Quick Reference, the building guide and a glossary. Chapters keep the numbers used everywhere else (the Character Builder, the arcade, the design notes), and every heading is numbered so you can cite a rule as, say, *§6.4* (positioning) or *§10.5* (building an encounter).

- **New player?** Read chapters 0, 1, 2A and 12, take a pregenerated freelancer from chapter 11, and play.
- **Making a character?** Chapter 2, then chapter 13 walks you through every box, or use the Character Builder.
- **Running the game?** Part Two. Fights are built from the budget in §10.5; the starter mission is chapter 11.
- **Theatre of the mind or a grid?** Both are full rules (§6.4). The web arcade plays the grid; chapter 14 lists the few places it differs from this book.

This book is compiled from the chapter files in the repository by `tools/build_rulebook.py`*; the chapters are the source, and a test keeps the two in step. Print edition: Mutagen_Rulebook.pdf.*

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Part One: Playing Mutagen

Everything a player needs: the core roll, building a freelancer, the Augment trees, Surges, Flux, combat, advancement and gear.

0. Introduction — Welcome to Halcyon



Mutagen is a tabletop roleplaying game about freelancers who rebuild their own bodies to survive a city that is rebuilding itself. There are no races and no classes. The Mutagen pulls you toward one of five **Base Forms** (Juggernaut, Skitter, Oracle, Alembic or Siren), and you become whatever you graft on along the way: chitin and venom, chrome and wire, or a twitching mix of both. Twice in your career you **Evolve**, suddenly and violently, into something far bigger. In a fight your body does not always do what you planned; it **Surges**, offering you a random handful of powers from everything you have ever become.

0.1 What You Need

- 3–5 players and one Game Master (GM).
- A d20 per player, plus a few d4, d6, d8, d10, and d12.
- A character sheet per player (sheets/).
- Tokens for **Juice** (coins, beads; 3 per player).

0.2 The Setting in One Page

Thirty years ago the **Ostrander Biotech Arcology**, a mile-high lab tower in the coastal megacity of **Halcyon**, cracked open. Millions of litres of **Mutagen**, a programmable living gel, poured into the water table. We call it **the Spill**.

Mutagen does one thing: it makes flesh *accept change*. A dose lets your body grow a new organ, or lets it accept a steel arm without rejection. Untamed, it makes rats fuse into hulks, mould think, and machines grow meat. The national government walled Halcyon off and outsourced the problem.

G.R.A.F.T. (Genetic Response And Field Tactics) is the private contractor that won the cleanup bid. GRAFT does not hire soldiers. It licenses **freelancers**: people already saturated with Mutagen who can go where clean humans die. You are one of them. GRAFT pays per mission, sells you upgrades at its clinics, and owns everything you bring back.

Factions in a sentence each:

- **GRAFT** — your employer. Polite, underfunded, and lying about what's in the samples.
- **Ostrander Remnant** — the old company, still alive in the upper arcology, sending sterile "Cleaner" squads to erase evidence.
- **The Children of the Bloom** — a faith that believes the Spill is the next step of evolution, and that you are halfway there.
- **The Scrapjacks** — chrome scavengers who strip the dead (and the living) for parts.
- **The Drowned Wards** — ordinary people living in the flooded lower city, trying not to become anything.

0.3 Tone

Gritty, weird, and a little funny. Bodies are strange and that is not tragic by default; it can be glorious, gross, or both. Missions are short and dangerous. The city is enormous and mostly unexplored.

0.4 The Big Ideas

1. **One roll for everything:** d20 + Stat (+ Rank) against a number. (Chapter 1)
2. **Emotive stats:** Grit, Moxie, Nerve, Gumption, Chutzpah. They describe *how* you do things, not what you are. (Chapter 2)
3. **You are your Form and your Augments:** five Base Forms, each growing along three of six 10-node skill trees (Hide, Limbs, Senses, Glands, Wiring, Mind), each tree grown as **Bio** or installed as **Chrome**. Evolutions at levels 4 and 7 transform your body and your numbers. (Chapter 2A, Chapter 3)
4. **Surges:** you build a personal list of combat powers from mix-and-match parts. Each fight, dice decide which few are ready. Using them is optional; your weapons and Augments always work. (Chapter 4)
5. **Flux:** every Surge pushes your body closer to **Overload**, where the Mutagen takes the wheel. (Chapter 5)
6. **Player-facing dice:** the GM rarely rolls. Players roll to hit, and players roll to dodge. (Chapter 6)
7. **One mission, one level:** a campaign runs 10 missions, levels 1 to 10. (Chapter 7)

1. Core Rules

Mutagen uses one roll for everything.

1.1 The Roll

> **Roll d20 + Stat (+ Rank, if it applies). Meet or beat the target number to succeed.**

- **Stat** is one of your five stats: −1 to +3 at level 1, rising to as high as **+8** as your Base Form Evolves (Chapter 2A), +10 in Final Form.
- **Rank** is your level-based bonus: **Rank = half your level, rounded up** (1 at level 1–2, up to 5 at level 9–10).
- You **always** add Rank to **attack rolls** and **defense rolls**.
- You add Rank to a **check** only if one of your **Knacks** applies.
- Ties go to the player.

There are three kinds of roll:

Roll	When	Target
Check	You try something risky outside of attacking or defending	A **DC** set by the GM
Attack	You try to hurt something	The target's **Guard**
Defense	Something tries to hurt you	The attacker's **Threat Number (TN)**

The GM almost never rolls. Enemies don't roll to hit you; **you roll to avoid them** (see Combat).

1.2 Difficulty (DC)

DC	Difficulty	Example
—	Trivial	No roll. Just do it.
10	Easy	Climb a chain-link fence in the rain
13	Standard	Talk a Ward guard into letting you pass
16	Hard	Hotwire an Ostrander security door
19	Extreme	Leap between two moving maglev cars
22	Mutant	Hold a collapsing ceiling up with your bare (augmented) back
25	Monstrous	Outrun a maglev; shout down a riot; read a stranger's mind from across a plaza
28	Mythic	Only an Evolved freelancer's primary stat even has a chance

Only roll when failure is interesting. On a failure, the GM picks a consequence: you fail, you succeed at a cost, or the situation gets worse.

DCs don't scale with level. A locked door is DC 16 whether you're level 1 or 9. Evolved freelancers simply *are* better at things their Form is good at: by level 7, a primary stat of +8 passes a Hard check on an 8+. Raise the stakes instead of the DC: higher-level missions put Extreme and Mutant obstacles in your path, and ask for checks with your weak stats. See Running the Game.

1.3 Knacks

A **Knack** is a short, specific phrase describing something you're trained in: *Street Medicine*, *Lying to Cops*, *Old Ostrander Tech*, *Parkour*, *Sewer Navigation*. When a Knack fits a check, add your Rank. If it's arguable, the GM decides; lean toward yes for narrow Knacks. You start with 3 Knacks and gain more as you level.

1.4 Advantage and Disadvantage

Advantage: roll 2d20, keep the higher. **Disadvantage:** roll 2d20, keep the lower. They don't stack; if you have both, roll normally.

Player-facing rule: if an *enemy* would have advantage on an attack, the defending player rolls their defense with **disadvantage**, and vice versa.

1.5 Natural 20s and 1s

- **Natural 20 on an attack:** a **Crit**. Roll the damage dice twice.
- **Natural 20 on a defense:** you avoid it entirely, and the attacker is **Exposed** (see Conditions).
- **Natural 20 on a check:** success, plus a bonus the GM describes.
- **Natural 1 on anything:** automatic failure.

1.6 Group Checks

When the whole party attempts something together (sneaking past, hauling a door), everyone rolls. If at least half succeed, the group succeeds.

1.7 Helping

To help someone, describe how and use your Action (in combat) or just do it (outside combat). They roll with advantage.

1.8 Juice

Juice is a reward token for great play: clever plans, bold roleplay, making the table laugh, or suffering for the story. The GM hands it out.

- You start each session with **1 Juice** and can hold **3**.
- Spend 1 Juice to do **one** of:
  - **Reroll** any d20 you just rolled (use the new result).
  - **Choose a Prime:** set one of your Sequence dice to any result you want (see Surges).
  - **Shrug:** end one condition on yourself.

1.9 Stats at a Glance

Stat	It's about	Rolls it covers
Grit	Toughness, force, refusal to fall over	Power melee, lifting, breaking, **Endure** defense, Max HP
Moxie	Daring, speed, flair under pressure	Finesse melee, sprinting, sneaking, climbing, **Dodge** defense, initiative

Stat	It's about	Rolls it covers
Nerve	Cool head, steady hands, willpower	Ranged attacks, noticing things, **Resist** defense, Flux Limit
Gumption	Resourcefulness, know-how, figuring it out	Tech, medicine, science, hacking, Analyze, Patch
Chutzpah	Audacity, charm, nerve-in-your-face	Persuade, lie, intimidate, perform, Taunt, Rally, psionic Surges

1.10 Rest

- **Breather** (about an hour, somewhere quiet): regain **half your Max HP**, Flux drops to **0**. You can take **two** Breathers between Lockdowns.
- **Lockdown** (8 hours in a safe place): regain all HP, Flux to 0, end temporary Overload effects, reset Breathers and "once per Lockdown" abilities.

1.11 Time and Distance

Combat runs in **rounds** (about 6 seconds). Distances are in feet. Play them either way (Positioning): in **theatre of the mind** use **Close** (5 ft, touching), **Near** (up to 30 ft, one move), **Far** (up to 120 ft) and **Distant** (beyond); on a **grid**, 1 square = 5 ft and diagonals count as one square.

1.12 Golden Rules

1. **Specific beats general.** An Augment or Surge that says otherwise wins.
2. **Round down** unless told otherwise (minimum 1 for damage).
3. **The GM decides** when the rules are unclear, then writes it down and moves on.

2. Character Creation



You don't pick a race or a class. You pick **what the Mutagen is turning you into** (your Base Form), **where you came from** (Origin), and **what you've done to your body** (Augments). It takes about 30 minutes; the web builder does the maths for you.

2.1 Step by Step

1. **Concept.** One sentence. *"Ex-cop with a shotgun arm who can't stop apologising."*
2. **Base Form.** Pick one of the five Base Forms: **Juggernaut, Skitter, Oracle, Alembic or Siren**. It sets your best stats, your three trees and how you'll Evolve.
3. **Stats.** Your Form gives **+3** (primary), **+2** (secondary) and **+1** (tertiary). Put **+0** and **−1** in the other two stats, in either order.
4. **Origin.** Pick or roll one (below). Write down its Knack and Perk.
5. **Knacks.** Write **two more** Knacks (3 total). Keep them narrow.
6. **Augments.** Take **6 nodes** from your Form's trees (chapter 3): the **Root + 2 Tier I nodes** of your primary tree, the **Root + 1 Tier I node** of your secondary tree, and the **Root** of your tertiary tree. For each tree, choose its **Material: Bio or Chrome**.
7. **Surges.** Build **3 Surges** (Chapter 4) and number them 1–3 on your Sequence. Slot 4 is Wild (Lab Escapees build a 4th instead).
8. **Gear.** Take one **Kit** from Gear and **50 Scrip**.
9. **Fill in the numbers** (below).
0. **Drive.** Answer three questions: *Why did you take the Mutagen? What do you want before the campaign ends? Who in Halcyon do you owe, or hate?*

2.2 Derived Numbers (Level 1)

Number	Value
Rank	1 (half your level, rounded up)
Max HP	12 + (2 × Grit) + 5 per level after 1st. Recalculate when Grit changes (it does at each Evolution).
Armor	From gear and the Hide tree (max 4, unless a node says otherwise)
Speed	30 ft (6 squares on a grid)
Flux Limit	4 + Rank + Nerve (minimum 4; Splice −1)
Sequence die	d4
Prime	2
Signature Surges	None yet (the first comes at Evolution I, level 4)
Juice	1 (max 3)
Defenses	Dodge = Moxie + Rank, Endure = Grit + Rank, Resist = Nerve + Rank

2.3 The Five Stats

Stats are attitudes, not body parts. A gangly kid can have huge Grit; it means they won't stay down. Your Base Form decides which attitudes the Mutagen feeds, and every Evolution feeds them more (up to **+8**).

- **Grit** — *"I'm still standing."* Raw force and stubborn endurance. Use it to smash, lift, grapple, hit hard in melee, and **Endure** poison, blasts, and crushing blows. It raises your HP.
- **Moxie** — *"Watch this."* Nimble daring. Use it to sprint, climb, sneak, tumble, fight with finesse weapons, and **Dodge** attacks you can see coming. It sets initiative.
- **Nerve** — *"Breathe. Aim."* Composure and willpower. Use it to shoot, notice, track, keep calm, and **Resist** fear, mind control, and psychic attack. It holds your Mutagen together (your **Flux Limit**).
- **Gumption** — *"Hand me that wrench."* Resourceful know-how. Use it to fix, hack, patch wounds, recall lore, read a situation, and **Analyze** enemies.
- **Chutzpah** — *"You and what army?"* Shameless audacity. Use it to persuade, lie, threaten, perform, lead, **Taunt** enemies, **Rally** allies, and power psionic **Dread** Surges.

> **Which defense?** Attacks you can sidestep (claws, bullets, spit) are **Dodge**. Things you must take on the chin (gas, explosions you can't escape, disease, grabs) are **Endure**. Things that attack your mind (fear, hacking your wetware, psychic screams) are **Resist**. Every threat's stat block names the defense.

2.4 Origins (roll d6 or choose)

d6	Origin	Knack	Perk
1	**Spill-Born** — raised in the flooded Wards.	*Scavenging*	Advantage on Endure against poison, disease, and anything that adds Flux to you.
2	**Corporate Washout** — ex-Ostrander staff, fired or fled.	*Corporate Protocol*	Start with +100 Scrip. Once per mission, name an old contact who can open one door.
3	**Lab Escapee** — you were the experiment.	*Lab Science*	You know **one extra Surge** at every level (it fills a Wild slot; no effect once your Sequence has no Wild slots). It never adds a Signature Surge.

d6	Origin	Knack	Perk
4	**Clinic Rat** — a street surgeon raised you, or still owns you.	*Street Medicine*	Your Patch action heals +Rank extra HP, and removing Scars or Faults costs you half (the doc wants favours instead).
5	**Ward Militia** — you held the barricades.	*Squad Tactics*	+2 to your roll in group initiative checks. Once per combat, take Brace as a Quick action.
6	**Bloom Convert** — the Children took you in.	*Bloom Lore*	Once per Lockdown, reroll an Overload result and choose either result.

2.5 Knack Examples

Parkour, Knife Fighting, Ostrander Security, Drone Piloting, Sewer Routes, Fast Talk, Interrogation, Chemistry, Mutant Biology, Salvage Appraisal, Street Medicine, Black-Market Contacts, Crowd Work, Lockpicking, Swimming, Gambling, Old Halcyon History, Cooking Anything, Bloom Scripture, Explosives.

A Knack should be something you could teach in a weekend course or learn on the street in a year. *"Everything Physical"* is not a Knack.

2.6 Example: Vex (Level 1)

- **Concept:** Wiry Spill-Born courier with mantis claws who runs messages through gang turf.
- **Form: Skitter.** Moxie +3, Gumption +2, Grit +1; she puts **Nerve +0** and **Chutzpah −1**.
- **Origin:** Spill-Born (*Scavenging*). Knacks: *Parkour*, *Gang Turf*.
- **Augments (6):** Wiring (Bio): **Quickened** (Root), **Capacitor**, **Slipstream**. Limbs (Bio): **Natural Weapons** (Root), **Spring Legs**. Senses (Bio): **Keen** (Root). She is all Bio, so Knit heals her 1 × 3 = 3 HP after each fight.
- **Surge parts:** base (Strike, Bolt, Infuse, Kinetic) + Wiring (Shock, Blaze, Haste) + Limbs (Wave, Snare) + Senses (Glare, Veil).
- **Surges:** 1 *Mantis Lunge* (Strike + Kinetic, Moxie), 2 *Live Wire* (Bolt + Shock, Moxie via Wiring), 3 *Slip Veil* (Infuse + Veil). 4 = Wild.
- **Gear:** Sneak kit (two knives, suppressed pistol, Breach kit), Light armor.
- **Numbers:** HP 14, Armor 1, Speed 50 ft (Quickened + Spring Legs), Limit 5 (4 + 1 + 0), Dodge +4, Endure +2, Resist +1. Claws: +4 to hit, 1d8+3, +1d8 Shock once per turn (Capacitor).
- **Her Evolution I** (level 4, Mantis): Moxie +5, Gumption +3, Grit +2, Nerve +1, Chutzpah +0; Prime 3, d8 Sequence, **Mantis Reflex**, and a Signature Surge (she'll pick *Live Wire*).

2A. Base Forms & Evolution

The Mutagen doesn't make you *anything*. It makes you into **something**: one of five shapes the city's freelancers keep turning into. That shape is your **Base Form**. It sets your best stats and the three Augment trees you grow along. Twice in your career it **Evolves**, suddenly and violently, into something bigger.

2A.1 Choosing a Form

Form	Primary +3	Secondary +2	Tertiary +1	You place +0 and −1 in	Primary tree	Secondary	Tertiary	In one line
Juggernaut	Grit	Nerve	Chutzpah	Moxie, Gumption	Hide	Limbs	Glands	*"I don't move. You do."*
Skitter	Moxie	Gumption	Grit	Nerve, Chutzpah	Wiring	Limbs	Senses	*"You blinked. I was already there."*
Oracle	Nerve	Chutzpah	Moxie	Grit, Gumption	Senses	Mind	Wiring	*"I saw you coming. Three days ago."*
Alembic	Gumption	Grit	Nerve	Moxie, Chutzpah	Glands	Hide	Mind	*"Hold still. This will either cure you or kill it."*
Siren	Chutzpah	Moxie	Gumption	Grit, Nerve	Mind	Wiring	Limbs	*"Everybody look at me."*

- **Stats:** your Form fixes your +3, +2 and +1. You put **+0** in one of the other two stats and **−1** in the last.
- **Trees:** you take nodes only from your Form's three trees (chapter 3): 3 in the primary, 2 in the secondary and 1 in the tertiary at level 1.
- **Material:** for each tree, choose **Bio or Chrome**, as before. A Chrome Oracle and a Bio Oracle both see everything, but one does it with lenses and the other with eyes.
- **Every stat** is primary for one Form, secondary for one and tertiary for one.

2A.2 Stages

Stage	Levels	Primary	Secondary	Tertiary	Dump (+0)	Dump (−1)
Base	1–3	+3	+2	+1	+0	−1
Evolution I	4–6	**+5**	+3	+2	+1	+0
Evolution II	7–10	**+8**	+4	+3	+2	+1
Final Form (active)	10	**+10**	+4	+3	+2	+1

There are no other stat increases. Your stats only change when your body does.

2A.3 What an Evolution Gives

Evolution I happens at **level 4** and **Evolution II** at **level 7**. Each one gives you all of the following:

	Evolution I (level 4)	Evolution II (level 7)
Stats	+2 primary, +1 every other stat	+3 primary, +1 every other stat
Prime	2 → **3**	3 → **4**
Sequence die	d6 → **d8**	d8 → **d12** (skips d10)
Signature Surge	Your **first** Signature Surge	Your **second** Signature Surge
Evolution node	Your Form's level 4 node	Your Form's level 7 node
Look	Your Form's Evolution I look	Your Form's Evolution II look

Your Max HP, defenses, Flux Limit and attacks all rise with the new stats. **Right after an Evolution, fights get noticeably easier.** The threats of the next few missions catch up with you (see Threats).

2A.3.1 Signature Surges

A Signature Surge is the power your new body was built around, and it's always there. You build it from your Surge parts like any Surge, with the Twists your Rank allows, and name it after what your body does now. It sits in its own Signature box (not on your Sequence), it's Primed at the start of every combat and again after each use, so you can Unleash it **once per round**, every round, for its normal Flux. The full rules are in Signature Surges.

- **Flux is the limit.** You can now Surge every turn, but every Surge pushes you toward Overload. Pace yourself, or plan your Overloads.

2A.3.2 Emergence: the moment it happens

You gain the level, and its numbers, at the debrief like any other level. The **metamorphosis plays out on screen**. At the start of your first turn in the **first combat** of your next mission, you **Emerge**. If you and the GM agree on an earlier moment of terror (a fall, a fire, a friend going Down), it happens then instead.

1. **Describe it.** Use your Form's look below: what splits, what grows, what you hear.
2. **Gain temporary HP equal to 2 × your level.**
3. **Every enemy within 30 ft** that can see you is **Shaken** (Bosses ignore this).
4. The **first time** you Unleash your new Signature Surge this combat, it's **Amped** (0 Flux).

Emerging takes no action. It happens once per Evolution.

> **GM tip.** Before the mission, ask the player: *"What's the first sign it's happening?"* Plant it in the Approach scene: an itch under the plating, a second heartbeat, a voice in the wiring. Optional downtime **Chrysalis** scene: see Running the Game.

2A.3.3 Final Form (level 10)

Your third and last stage. At level 10 you take your Form's **Final look** for good. Once per Lockdown, at the start of a combat (after Priming), you may enter **Final Form** until the combat ends:

- **+2 to your primary stat** (to +10).
- **Prime two extra Surges** right away (your Primed maximum rises to match).
- **Every Surge you Unleash is Amped** (0 Flux), Signature Surges included.

2A.4 The Five Forms

2A.4.1 Juggernaut

Primary Grit · Secondary Nerve · Tertiary Chutzpah · Dump Moxie and Gumption · Trees: Hide (primary), Limbs (secondary), Glands (tertiary)

"I don't move. You do." The Mutagen decided you should be **unkillable** and started stacking. Juggernauts hold doorways, carry the wounded, and end arguments by standing in them. Grit and Nerve make them hard to hurt and harder to scare, and a little Chutzpah helps them loom. They're slow off the mark and not much for book-learning.

- **Play it if** you want to be the wall: Taunt, intercept, and take the hit meant for your friend.
- **Evolution nodes: Siege Hide** (level 4): +1 Armor, Armor max 6, reach 10 ft, counts as Huge. **Fortress** (level 7): allies near you take half Area damage, and once per round you take an ally's lethal hit.

Stage	Name	Bio	Chrome
Base	**Juggernaut**	Thick neck, heavy brow, knuckles armoured with horn. Your skin has the give of a car tyre.	Subdermal plates you can feel through your shirt; a spine brace that whines when you stand.
Evolution I	**Rampart**	You grow a foot in a night. Your back splits into overlapping bone slabs; your forearms swell into shields.	Bulkhead plates bolt over shoulders and chest; your joints are hydraulic now, and they hiss.
Evolution II	**Colossus**	Nine feet of keratin and scar tissue. Horns, a domed skull, a heartbeat people feel through the floor.	A walking bunker: riveted armour, a face behind a visor slit, treads of steel on your soles.
Final	**Citadel**	Stone-hard ridges, moss in the cracks, small things nesting in you. You are a place.	Siren lights, warning stencils, a hatch in your chest. Ostrander would classify you as infrastructure.

2A.4.2 Skitter

Primary Moxie · Secondary Gumption · Tertiary Grit · Dump Nerve and Chutzpah · Trees: Wiring (primary), Limbs (secondary), Senses (tertiary)

"You blinked. I was already there." The Mutagen took your nerves and set them on fire. Skitters are the fastest thing in any room: clever with their hands, wiry, and impossible to pin down. They're also jumpy, tactless and short on Flux; their Nerve is the first thing to go.

- **Play it if** you want to dart in, Daze, dart out, and act more often than anyone else.
- **Evolution nodes: Mantis Reflex** (level 4): two Reactions per round, and full-damage Reflex Spikes. **Lightning Step** (level 7): a half-dice weapon attack as a Quick action after you Unleash.

Stage	Name	Bio	Chrome
Base	**Skitter**	Long limbs, twitchy hands, pupils that never settle; you're warm to the touch.	Reflex jacks at the base of the skull; fingertips with steel contacts that spark when you're nervous.
Evolution I	**Mantis**	Your forearms fold into barbed hooks; your knees bend backwards; you smell like ozone.	Synthetic muscle cables under translucent skin, and a capacitor hump between your shoulders.
Evolution II	**Wraith**	Glassy wing-cases that hum, faceted eyes, lightning crawling along your veins.	You blur when you move; a plasma coil glows through your ribs; you leave scorch-prints.

Stage	Name	Bio	Chrome
Final	**Livewire**	Barely solid: a figure of arcs and chitin that's always slightly somewhere else.	A human-shaped storm in a chrome cage, held together by a magnetic field.

2A.4.3 Oracle

Primary Nerve · Secondary Chutzpah · Tertiary Moxie · Dump Grit and Gumption · Trees: Senses (primary), Mind (secondary), Wiring (tertiary)

"I saw you coming. Three days ago." The Mutagen gave you **too much input**, and you learned to stay calm inside it. Oracles see everything, steady everyone and hold the most Flux of any Form (their high Nerve raises their Flux Limit). They're light on their feet but physically fragile and impractical; their aim isn't.

- **Play it if** you want to shoot from a rooftop, spot every weakness, and decide which way the dice fall.
- **Evolution nodes: Foresight** (level 4): each round, an Omen d20 that can replace any nearby d20. **Thousand Eyes** (level 7): Target Lock on three creatures, no surprise or Blindness nearby, wider Crits.

Stage	Name	Bio	Chrome
Base	**Oracle**	Pale, still, unsettling eyes with too much iris; you hear heartbeats through walls.	A monocle lens grafted to the socket; tiny antennae behind the ears.
Evolution I	**Argus**	A third eye opens on your brow; small eyes bead along your collarbones and blink out of time.	A ring of lenses around your head like a crown; your voice comes with a faint radio hiss.
Evolution II	**Seraph**	Wing-like membranes covered in eyes unfold from your back; you float a hand's width off the floor.	Six optic arms fan out from your spine; holographic targeting halos hang around you.
Final	**Panopticon**	A tall white shape of lids and lashes; when you look at someone, they feel *seen*.	A tower of lenses and dishes; every camera in the district turns toward you.

2A.4.4 Alembic

Primary Gumption · Secondary Grit · Tertiary Nerve · Dump Moxie and Chutzpah · Trees: Glands (primary), Hide (secondary), Mind (tertiary)

"Hold still. This will either cure you or kill it." The Mutagen made you a **laboratory**. Alembics brew medicine and poison in their own bodies, stay standing in toxic air, and keep the whole crew alive. They're slow, tough and steady-handed, with a bedside manner best described as *blunt*.

- **Play it if** you want to heal, poison, and out-think the problem.
- **Evolution nodes: Transmute** (level 4): your Toxin and Corrode riders apply both Poisoned and Exposed, and your healing restores more. **Panacea** (level 7): once per combat, heal everyone nearby and end their conditions.

Stage	Name	Bio	Chrome
Base	**Alembic**	Glands swelling at the throat and wrists; you sweat something sweet-smelling and faintly green.	Injector ports along your forearms, and a hip-mounted reservoir with a gauge.
Evolution I	**Still**	Translucent sacs bloom across your back, glowing with what you're brewing; your breath fogs.	Coiled tubing and glass vials under a ribcage of chrome; you gurgle when you walk.

Stage	Name	Bio	Chrome
Evolution II	**Bloomheart**	Spore-fronds and flower-like vents open along your spine; insects follow you.	A walking refinery: pressurised tanks, nozzle arrays, a warning placard that reads FLAMMABLE.
Final	**Wellspring**	A living garden: roots in the floor where you stand, fruit that heals, pollen that kills.	A mobile clinic: hissing pipes, a dozen spigots, steam that smells like hospitals.

2A.4.5 Siren

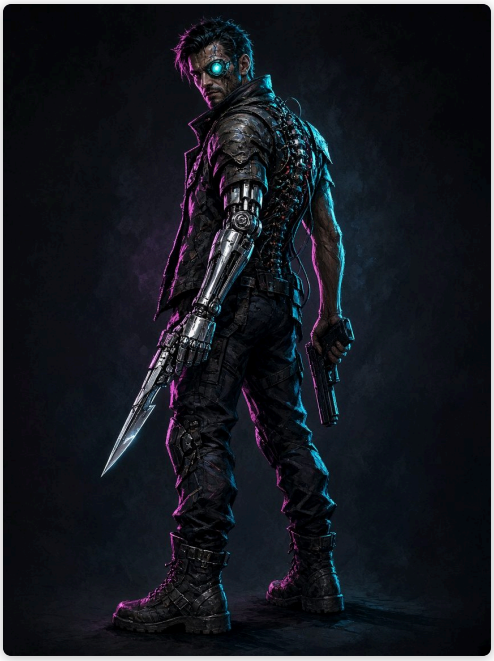
Primary Chutzpah · Secondary Moxie · Tertiary Gumption · Dump Grit and Nerve · Trees: Mind (primary), Wiring (secondary), Limbs (tertiary)

"Everybody look at me." The Mutagen made you **impossible to ignore**. Sirens command attention: they talk past guards, Taunt whole rooms, and bend minds. They're quick enough to dodge the attention they draw and sharp enough to improvise, but fragile, reckless, and the first to Overload (their low Nerve means a low Flux Limit).

- **Play it if** you want to lead, talk, Taunt and control the battlefield.
- **Evolution nodes: Siren Song** (level 4): a Quick mass Taunt that sends every Taunted enemy at you or an ally you name (usually your Juggernaut), at −2 TN. **Crown of Will** (level 7): once per combat, a non-Boss fights for you.

Stage	Name	Bio	Chrome
Base	**Siren**	Striking face, a voice with a second note under it, a scent people remember.	Voice modulator at the throat; LED tattoos that pulse when you talk.
Evolution I	**Diva**	Iridescent skin, a frill of feathers or fins at the neck; your voice harmonises with itself.	Speaker grilles bloom along your collarbones; your face projects a light-show halo.
Evolution II	**Choir**	A crown of soft horns; a dozen mouths open along your arms and sing in chorus.	An antenna crown and a cape of fibre-optic cable; you broadcast on every frequency.
Final	**Crowned**	Too beautiful to look at directly; people weep, kneel or flee.	A living billboard and a broadcast tower; your face is on every screen, saying *your* name.

3. Augment Trees



Your Augments are what you've done to your body. Your **Base Form** (chapter 2A) decides which **three trees** you grow along: a **primary** tree you master, a **secondary** you lean on, and a **tertiary** you dabble in. There are six trees, and each one is a body system you've rebuilt. Each can be **grown (Bio)** or **installed (Chrome)**.

Tree	Stat	Role	Unlocks	Primary of	Secondary of	Tertiary of
Hide	Grit	Tank, protector	Pulse (Shape), Quake, Shell	Juggernaut	Alembic	—
Limbs	Grit / Moxie	Melee, grappler, mover	Wave (Shape), Snare	—	Juggernaut, Skitter	Siren
Senses	Nerve	Sniper, scout, spotter	Glare, Veil	Oracle	—	Skitter
Glands	Gumption	Chemist, healer, attrition	Burst (Shape), Toxin, Corrode, Mend	Alembic	—	Juggernaut
Wiring	Moxie	Speed, reflexes, shock	Shock, Blaze, Haste	Skitter	Siren	Oracle
Mind	Chutzpah	Psionics, hacking, control	Dread, Link	Siren	Oracle	Alembic

3.1 How Trees Work

- **Ten nodes per tree:** a **Root**, four **Tier I** nodes, four **Tier II** nodes, and an **Apex**. A Form's primary tree also holds that Form's two **Evolution nodes**.
- **You only take nodes from your Form's three trees.**
- **Gates:**

Node	Needs
Root	Nothing. You take all three Roots at level 1.
Tier I	The tree's Root
Tier II	**Level 4+** and **3 nodes** already in that tree
Apex	**Level 7+**, **6 other nodes** in that tree, and it must be your **primary or secondary** tree
Evolution node	Your Form, at level 4 (Evolution I) or level 7 (Evolution II). Granted automatically.

"Nodes in that tree" counts your standard nodes (Root, Tier I, Tier II); **Evolution nodes don't count toward a gate.**

- **Scaling.** Nodes scale with your **Rank**; you never need a "greater" version. A node is taken once.
- **Push.** Some nodes say **Push**: you may gain **1 Flux** to get the extra effect (Chapter 5).
- **Unlocks.** Each tree unlocks **Surge parts** (Chapter 4) the moment you take its Root. Since you take all three Roots at level 1, your Form fixes your Surge parts.

3.2 Gaining Nodes

When	Primary tree	Secondary or tertiary tree
Level 1	**3 nodes** (Root + 2)	**2 nodes** in the secondary (Root + 1) and **1 node** in the tertiary (its Root)
Each level after	**+1 node, automatically.** You always get it, and you choose which.	**+1 node** in your secondary **or** tertiary tree (your choice)
Level 4 and 7	**+ your Form's Evolution node** (on top of the pick)	—

- **Primary tree full?** Its 10 standard nodes fill up at level 8. From level 9, the automatic primary pick **overflows** into your secondary or tertiary tree.
- **Totals:** 2 × level + 4 nodes, plus Evolution nodes: **6 at level 1, 13 at level 4, 20 at level 7, 26 at level 10.**
- **Respec.** When you level up, you may swap one node for another of the same pick type that you qualify for. The clinic rips it out.

3.3 Material: Bio or Chrome

When you take a tree's Root, choose its **Material**: grown or installed. Every node in that tree shares it. Material changes how the tree looks and adds the rules below. *(v0.1 called this "Form"; that word now means your Base Form.)*

Material	Looks like	Perk	Cost
Bio (grown)	Chitin, scales, extra eyes, glands, tentacles, glowing veins	**Knit:** at the end of each combat, and when you take a Breather, regain HP equal to **Rank × your number of Bio trees**.	Your Overloads roll on the **Bloom** table.
Chrome (installed)	Plates, pistons, optics, ports, wiring, servo-arms	**Firmware:** once per combat, right after you Prime, you may swap one Primed Surge for any Surge you know that uses a part unlocked by one of your Chrome trees (base parts alone don't count).	Your Overloads roll on the **Glitch** table. You roll defense with **disadvantage against Shock** attacks. **Upkeep:** 25 Scrip per Chrome tree each mission (GRAFT prepays your first), or start the mission with +1 Flux per unpaid tree.

Material	Looks like	Perk	Cost
Splice (you have both)	Meat and metal fighting for the same body	Overload: roll on **both** tables, then choose one result. Each tree keeps its own Material rules.	Your Flux Limit is **−1** (after the minimum of 4).

Your Evolutions follow your Materials: a Bio Juggernaut's Rampart stage grows bone slabs, a Chrome one bolts on bulkheads.

3.4 The Evolution Nodes at a Glance

Form	Primary tree	Level 4: Evolution I	Level 7: Evolution II
Juggernaut	Hide	**Siege Hide:** +1 Armor, Armor max 6, reach 10 ft, counts as Huge	**Fortress:** allies within 10 ft take half Area damage; take an ally's lethal hit
Skitter	Wiring	**Mantis Reflex:** two Reactions per round; Reflex Spike and Opportunity Strikes use full dice	**Lightning Step:** after you Unleash, a half-dice weapon attack as a Quick action
Oracle	Senses	**Foresight:** each round, an Omen d20 that can replace any nearby d20	**Thousand Eyes:** Target Lock ×3, no surprise or Blindness nearby, wider Crits
Alembic	Glands	**Transmute:** Toxin/Corrode riders apply Poisoned *and* Exposed; healing +Gumption	**Panacea:** once per combat, heal the whole party and end their conditions
Siren	Mind	**Siren Song:** a Quick mass Taunt that sends enemies at you or an ally you name, at −2 TN	**Crown of Will:** once per combat, a non-Boss fights for you

3.5 Building With Trees

Your Form decides your trees, but which nodes you take decides your role.

Form	Leans toward…	…or toward
Juggernaut	Doorway-holder: Plating, Menace, Living Wall, Bulwark	Brawler: Limbs Crusher Grip, Rend, Flurry
Skitter	Duelist: Capacitor, Reflex Spike, Kinetic Battery	Runner and skirmisher: Slipstream, Arc Jump, Spring Legs, Pounce
Oracle	Sniper: Target Lock, Long Sight, Deadeye	Spotter: Analyzer, Weak Spot, Spotter, Precog
Alembic	Medic: Stim Gland, Antibodies, Living Pharmacy	Poisoner: Spit, Catalyst, Spore Cloud, Burst Surges
Siren	Commander: Commanding Voice, Hive Mind, Haste Surges	Controller: Puppet, Psychic Scream, Snare Waves

3.6 Hide — the body as a fortress

Bio: chitin plates, scales, rubbery blubber, bark-skin. Chrome: dermal plating, kinetic mesh, ablative shell.

Stat: Grit · **Role:** tank, protector · **Unlocks:** Pulse (Shape), Quake, Shell · **Primary tree of:** Juggernaut · **Secondary of:** Alembic

3.6.1 Root

- **Plating.** +1 Armor (**+2 from Rank 3**). Armor from all sources maxes at 4, unless a node says otherwise.

3.6.2 Tier I (needs the Root)

- **Thick.** +2 Max HP per level (count past levels too).
- **Barbs.** When an enemy's melee attack damages you, it takes **2 × Rank** damage.
- **Anchor.** You can't be knocked Prone, pushed or pulled against your will. You roll defense with advantage against attacks whose rider is Held.
- **Shoulder Check.** Once per turn, you can Grapple or Shove as a Quick action.

3.6.3 Tier II (needs level 4+ and 3 nodes in this tree)

- **Adaptive.** When you take Blaze, Shock, Toxin, Corrode or Psychic damage, you resist that type (half damage) until combat ends. One type at a time; a new type replaces the old.
- **Bulwark.** *Reaction:* when an ally within 10 ft is targeted by a Single attack, you become the target instead and roll your own defense. **Push:** roll it with advantage.
- **Living Wall.** Allies adjacent to you get **+1** to defense rolls (**+2 from Rank 4**). It doesn't stack with another Living Wall.
- **Menace.** You can Taunt as a Quick action, using Grit in place of Chutzpah. You get **+2** to defense rolls against creatures you have Taunted.

3.6.4 Apex (needs level 7+, 6 other nodes in this tree, and this must be your primary or secondary tree)

- **Unbreakable.** Once per round, when you fail a defense roll, **Push** to take half damage and ignore its rider. Your Armor maximum is 5.

3.6.5 Evolution nodes (Juggernaut only; granted automatically)

- **Siege Hide** *(level 4, Evolution I).* Your hide thickens into overlapping slabs. +1 Armor, and your Armor maximum is **6**. Your melee reach is 10 ft, and you count as **Huge** (non-Huge creatures can't knock you Prone or push you).
- **Fortress** *(level 7, Evolution II).* You are terrain now. Allies within 10 ft of you take **half damage from Area attacks** (after their own defense roll). *Reaction:* once per round, when an ally within 30 ft would drop to 0 HP, you take that damage instead (your Armor applies).

3.7 Limbs — claws, legs, and too many arms

Bio: claws, mantis blades, tentacles, extra arms, digitigrade legs. Chrome: piston arms, mono-blades, grapple lines, servo-arms, hydraulic legs.

Stat: Grit or Moxie · **Role:** melee, grappler, mover · **Unlocks:** Wave (Shape), Snare · **Secondary tree of:** Juggernaut, Skitter · **Tertiary of:** Siren

Limbs is the **shared body tree**. It is never a Form's primary tree, so it has no Evolution nodes. Its Apex is open to the Juggernaut and the Skitter, who have it as their secondary tree.

3.7.1 Root

- **Natural Weapons.** Claws, blades or pistons: a melee weapon (**d8**, Grit or Moxie) that can't be disarmed and doesn't need a free hand.

3.7.2 Tier I (needs the Root)

- **Extra Arm.** A third limb. Hold one more item, and draw, stow or interact without using your Quick action. Once per turn, when you hit with a melee attack, deal **+1 damage die** (one more of that attack's dice). **Push:** also knock the target Prone (not Huge).
- **Grapnel.** Your melee reach is 10 ft. As your Move, you can pull yourself up to 30 ft to any surface you can see, or yank an unheld object to your hand.
- **Spring Legs.** +10 ft speed. Jump 20 ft long or 10 ft high as part of your move, climb at full speed, and take half falling damage.
- **Lash Tail.** You can make an Opportunity Strike when an enemy **enters** your melee reach, as well as when it leaves. A hit from an Opportunity Strike knocks a non-Huge target Prone.

3.7.3 Tier II (needs level 4+ and 3 nodes in this tree)

- **Crusher Grip.** Once per turn when you hit with a natural weapon, the target is **Held**. Huge creatures and Bosses require a **Push**.
- **Rend.** Your natural weapons' die becomes **d10** (**d12 from Rank 4**).
- **Pounce.** Once per turn, if you move at least 15 ft toward a creature and then hit it with a melee attack, it's knocked Prone (not Huge), and you can Grapple it as a Quick action.
- **Many Hands.** Help is a Quick action for you. You can hold a second creature Held while you already hold one.

3.7.4 Apex (needs level 7+, 6 other nodes in this tree, and this must be your primary or secondary tree)

- **Flurry.** When you take the Attack action with natural weapons, make a second attack with half the damage dice (round up).

3.8 Senses — eyes everywhere

Bio: compound eyes, pit organs, bat ears, whiskers, a third eye. Chrome: optic suites, targeting HUD, radar, audio filters.

Stat: Nerve · **Role:** sniper, scout, spotter · **Unlocks:** Glare, Veil · **Primary tree of:** Oracle · **Tertiary of:** Skitter

3.8.1 Root

- **Keen.** See in darkness out to 60 ft. Advantage on checks to notice hidden things. Bright light can't Blind you.

3.8.2 Tier I (needs the Root)

- **Target Lock.** *Quick:* mark a creature you can see. Once per turn, your attack against it deals **+1 damage die** (one more of that attack's dice). The mark lasts until combat ends or you mark another.
- **Threat Sense.** You and your group can't be surprised. *Reaction:* when an ally within 30 ft makes a defense roll, add your Nerve to it (declare before rolling).
- **Analyzer.** You can **Analyze** as a Quick action once per turn.
- **Echolocation.** You sense creatures within 30 ft without sight. You can't be Blinded against anything within that range, and hidden or invisible creatures there are revealed to you.

3.8.3 Tier II (needs level 4+ and 3 nodes in this tree)

- **Long Sight.** Double the range of your ranged attacks and ranged Surges. Ignore partial cover. Read lips at 300 ft.
- **Weak Spot.** When you Analyze a creature, its Armor and Resistances don't apply to anyone's damage until the end of its next turn.
- **Spotter.** *Quick,* once per round: an ally within 60 ft who can hear you gets advantage on its next attack against a creature you can see.
- **Hair Trigger.** When a combat starts, after Priming and before anyone else acts, you may make one ranged weapon attack.

3.8.4 Apex (needs level 7+, 6 other nodes in this tree, and this must be your primary or secondary tree)

- **Deadeye.** Your ranged attacks (weapons, Spit, Mind Spike, ranged Surges) Crit on 18–20. Once per round, **Push** to reroll a missed attack.

3.8.5 Evolution nodes (Oracle only; granted automatically)

- **Foresight** *(level 4, Evolution I).* A lidless third eye opens. At the start of each round, roll a d20 and set it aside: your **Omen**. Once before the round ends, after any d20 is rolled by you or an ally within 60 ft, you may replace that roll with the Omen. An unused Omen fades at the end of the round.
- **Thousand Eyes** *(level 7, Evolution II).* Eyes open all over you. Target Lock can mark up to **three** creatures at once. You and allies within 60 ft can't be surprised or Blinded. Your ranged attacks ignore partial cover, and their Crit range is one wider than it would otherwise be: 20 → 19–20, 19–20 → 18–20, 18–20 → 17–20. This is an exception to the rule that Crit ranges don't stack.

3.9 Glands — the walking pharmacy

Bio: venom sacs, acid glands, healing bile, spore pods. Chrome: chem injectors, nanite reservoirs, drug pumps, nozzle ports.

Stat: Gumption · **Role:** chemist, healer, attrition · **Unlocks:** Burst (Shape), Toxin, Corrode, Mend · **Primary tree of:** Alembic · **Tertiary of:** Juggernaut

3.9.1 Root

- **Spit.** A ranged natural attack (**d8**, 30 ft, Nerve or Gumption) dealing Toxin or Corrode damage (choose each time). Advantage on Endure against poison.

3.9.2 Tier I (needs the Root)

- **Regenerate.** At the start of your turn, if you're at half HP or less (and not Down), regain **Rank + 1** HP.
- **Stim Gland.** *Action* (or *Quick* with **Push**): you or a creature you touch regains **Rank d6 + Gumption** HP and ends Burning or Poisoned. Twice per Breather.
- **Adrenal Dump.** The first time each combat you drop to half HP or less, gain **2 × Rank + Grit** temporary HP and advantage on your next attack.
- **Antibodies.** You can't be Poisoned. *Quick,* once per Breather: end one condition on a creature you touch.

3.9.3 Tier II (needs level 4+ and 3 nodes in this tree)

- **Purge.** Once per combat, *Quick:* lose Flux equal to **Rank + 1** and take that much damage (ignores Armor).
- **Catalyst.** Your Burst Surges roll **d8** damage dice instead of d6.
- **Spore Cloud.** *Action,* once per combat, **Push:** exhale a 15-ft-radius cloud centred on you that lasts until the end of next round. Creatures outside it can't see into it. You and your allies inside are Veiled against attacks made from outside the cloud.
- **Mutagen Tap.** Once per round, when you would gain Flux, you may take **Rank + 1** damage per point instead (ignores Armor; it can't drop you below 1 HP).

3.9.4 Apex (needs level 7+, 6 other nodes in this tree, and this must be your primary or secondary tree)

- **Living Pharmacy.** Stim Gland affects you and every ally within 15 ft at once. Your Mend Surges cost no Flux.

3.9.5 Evolution nodes (Alembic only; granted automatically)

- **Transmute** *(level 4, Evolution I).* Your glands learn to brew anything. When your Toxin or Corrode damage applies its rider, the target is both **Poisoned and Exposed**. Your healing (Stim Gland, Mend Surges, Patch) restores **+Gumption** HP.
- **Panacea** *(level 7, Evolution II).* Your blood is medicine. Once per combat, *Action:* you and every ally within 30 ft regain **(Rank + 1)d8 + Gumption** HP, end all conditions, and lose 2 Flux. A Down ally stands up.

3.10 Wiring — faster than you should be

Bio: hyper-fast nerves, eel-organs, adrenal crystals. Chrome: reflex boosters, synthetic muscle, capacitor banks, plasma coils.

Stat: Moxie · **Role:** speed, reflexes, shock · **Unlocks:** Shock, Blaze, Haste · **Primary tree of:** Skitter · **Secondary of:** Siren · **Tertiary of:** Oracle

3.10.1 Root

- **Quickened.** +10 ft speed. You can **Dash** as a Quick action. Your group has advantage on initiative checks.

3.10.2 Tier I (needs the Root)

- **Reflex Spike.** *Reaction,* **Push:** when you succeed on a Dodge against a melee attack, make one weapon attack against the attacker with half the damage dice (round up).
- **Capacitor.** Once per turn when you hit with a melee attack, deal **+1 damage die** (one more of that attack's dice) as Shock. **Push:** the target is also Dazed.
- **Slipstream.** You never provoke Opportunity Strikes, can move through enemies' spaces, and take **no** damage when you succeed on a Dodge against an Area attack.
- **Wall Run.** As part of your Move you can run along walls and across liquids, as long as you end the Move on something that holds you (otherwise you fall).

3.10.3 Tier II (needs level 4+ and 3 nodes in this tree)

- **Overclock.** Once per Breather, take one extra Action on your turn, then gain 1 Flux.
- **Arc Jump.** Once per turn, as part of your Move, flash up to 20 ft in a straight line, passing through creatures' spaces. **Push:** each creature you pass through takes **2 × Rank** Shock damage.
- **Kinetic Battery.** Each time you succeed on a Dodge, store a charge (max 3). When you hit with an attack, you may spend all your charges: **+1 damage die per charge**, as Shock. Charges fade when combat ends.
- **Afterimage.** When you Dash, you are Veiled until the start of your next turn.

3.10.4 Apex (needs level 7+, 6 other nodes in this tree, and this must be your primary or secondary tree)

- **Blur.** You get two Moves each turn. If you've moved 20+ ft this turn, roll your first Dodge each round with advantage until your next turn.

3.10.5 Evolution nodes (Skitter only; granted automatically)

- **Mantis Reflex** *(level 4, Evolution I).* Your nerves fire before you think. You get **two Reactions** per round (both refresh at the start of your turn). Your Reflex Spike and Opportunity Strikes use your full damage dice.
- **Lightning Step** *(level 7, Evolution II).* You move between moments. Once per turn, after you Unleash a Surge, you may make **one weapon attack as a Quick action**, with half its damage dice (round up).

3.11 Mind — the voice in every head

Bio: swollen cortex, psionic nodules, pheromone glands, a voice that echoes. Chrome: neural coprocessor, wetware deck, voice modulator, antenna crown.

Stat: Chutzpah · **Role:** psionics, hacking, control, leadership · **Unlocks:** Dread, Link · **Primary tree of:** Siren · **Secondary of:** Oracle · **Tertiary of:** Alembic

3.11.1 Root

- **Uplink.** Speak mind-to-mind (Bio) or by encrypted radio (Chrome) with willing creatures within 300 ft. **Mind Spike:** a ranged attack (**d8**, 60 ft, Nerve or Chutzpah) dealing Psychic damage.

3.11.2 Tier I (needs the Root)

- **Intrude.** *Action:* Gumption or Chutzpah + Rank vs a creature's TN (or a device's DC). Read its surface thoughts, or seize an unattended device for 1 minute. In combat, a Mook machine obeys you until the end of next round; any other machine is Dazed.
- **Iron Will.** Advantage on Resist, and you can't be Shaken. Allies within 30 ft get +1 to Resist.
- **Commanding Voice.** You can **Rally** as a Quick action.
- **Read the Room.** Advantage on checks to spot a lie. Once per scene, ask the GM what a creature you can see wants or fears most right now; the answer is true.

3.11.3 Tier II (needs level 4+ and 3 nodes in this tree)

- **Puppet.** *Action,* **Push:** Chutzpah + Rank vs the TN of a non-Boss creature. On a success, it immediately does one of these, your choice: moves up to its speed where you choose, or makes one attack against a target you choose. An enemy target simply takes the attack's Damage (no roll, no rider); a player target defends normally.
- **Precog.** *Reaction,* **Push:** when you or an ally within 30 ft is about to make a d20 roll (declare before rolling), they roll it with advantage.
- **Psychic Scream.** *Action,* once per combat: make one Chutzpah attack (an **Area** attack) against every enemy within 30 ft that you choose. Hit: **(Rank + 1)d6** Psychic and Shaken. Miss: half damage.
- **Glamour.** *Quick,* **Push:** you are Veiled until the end of next round.

3.11.4 Apex (needs level 7+, 6 other nodes in this tree, and this must be your primary or secondary tree)

- **Hive Mind.** Once per round, an ally within 300 ft can use your Nerve or Chutzpah in place of theirs for one roll. At the start of each combat, choose one ally: they Prime one extra Surge.

3.11.5 Evolution nodes (Siren only; granted automatically)

- **Siren Song** *(level 4, Evolution I).* Your voice splits into harmonies. Once per round you can Taunt as a Quick action, and your Taunt can target every enemy within 30 ft you choose (compare one roll to each creature's TN). Each enemy you Taunt this way must target **you or one ally you name** within 30 ft of you (same ally for all of them) if it can, and has **−2 TN** against that creature's defense rolls until the Taunt ends.
- **Crown of Will** *(level 7, Evolution II).* Once per combat, *Action,* **Push:** Chutzpah + Rank vs the TN of a creature within 60 ft. A **non-Boss** obeys you until the end of combat. In each Enemy

Phase it acts as you choose (it won't harm itself), and it breaks free if you or an ally damages it. A **Boss** instead loses its next Interrupt and is Dazed until the end of its next turn.

4. Surges & the Sequence



Mutagen doesn't take orders well. In a fight, your body offers you a few of its powers at random: a spurt of acid, a crackle of arc-light, a shell that snaps shut. These are **Surges**. They are **optional**. Your weapons and Augments always work; Surges are the big, unreliable spikes on top.

4.1 The Short Version

1. You **build** Surges from parts and write them on your **Sequence** (a numbered list).
2. At the start of each fight you **Prime**: roll your **Sequence die** a few times. The Surges you roll are ready.
3. On your turn you may **Unleash** a Primed Surge as your Action. It costs **Flux**.
4. Want more options? **Churn** as a Quick action to roll again.
5. From your first **Evolution** (level 4) you also have **Signature Surges** that are always ready (below).

4.2 Building a Surge

A Surge = **one Shape + one Effect** (+ optional **Twist**). Name it and describe what it looks like. *Bolt + Corrode* might be "Acid Spit" for a Bio freelancer or "Etching Laser" for a Chrome one.

You can use any **base** part, plus parts **unlocked** by trees you have the Root of.

4.2.1 Shapes (how it's delivered)

Shape	Unlock	Target	Attack stat	Damage on hit
Strike	base	One creature in melee reach	Grit or Moxie	(Rank+1)**d10** + stat
Bolt	base	One creature within 60 ft	Nerve	(Rank+1)**d8** + stat
Burst	Glands	Everything in a 10-ft radius within 60 ft	Nerve	(Rank+1)**d6**

Shape	Unlock	Target	Attack stat	Damage on hit
Wave	Limbs	15-ft cone or 30-ft line from you	Grit or Nerve	(Rank+1)**d6**
Pulse	Hide	Any creatures you choose within 10 ft of you	Grit	(Rank+1)**d6**
Infuse	base	You or one ally within 30 ft	— (no roll)	Uses an Infuse Effect

Area Shapes (Burst, Wave, Pulse): roll one attack and compare it to each target's Guard. **Hit:** full damage + Effect. **Miss:** half damage, no Effect. Allies in a Burst or Wave are hit too (they roll Dodge against your attack total; success = half damage, no rider); a Pulse hits only the creatures you choose. Footprints on a grid (a 10-ft radius is 5×5 squares, a 15-ft cone is 3 squares deep) are in Combat.

Attack stat. A Surge uses its Shape's attack stat, **or** the stat of the tree that unlocked its Effect, whichever you prefer:

Effect's tree	Hide	Limbs	Senses	Glands	Wiring	Mind
Stat it allows	Grit	Grit or Moxie	Nerve	Gumption	Moxie	Chutzpah

Bolt + Shock can use Nerve (Bolt) or Moxie (Wiring); *Burst + Toxin* can use Nerve or Gumption (Glands); *Wave + Dread* can use Grit, Nerve or Chutzpah (Mind). Base Effects (Kinetic) use the Shape's stat only.

4.2.2 Effects (what it does)

Damage Effects go with Strike, Bolt, Burst, Wave, or Pulse. The rider applies on a hit (conditions are in Combat).

Effect	Unlock	Damage type	Rider on hit
Kinetic	base	Kinetic	+1 damage die, and you may push the target 10 ft
Blaze	Wiring	Blaze	Burning
Shock	Wiring	Shock	Dazed
Toxin	Glands	Toxin	Poisoned
Corrode	Glands	Corrode	Exposed
Snare	Limbs	Kinetic	Held
Quake	Hide	Kinetic	Prone (not Huge)
Glare	Senses	Blaze	Blinded
Dread	Mind	Psychic	Shaken

Infuse Effects go only with Infuse. No roll, no miss.

Effect	Unlock	What happens
Mend	Glands	Target regains (Rank+1)d8 + Gumption HP and ends Burning and Poisoned. A Down target stands up.
Shell	Hide	Target gains (Rank+1)d6 + Grit temporary HP and +1 Armor until the end of next round.
Haste	Wiring	An **ally** (not you) immediately takes a Move and one Action (not Unleash), with advantage on any roll that Action needs.
Veil	Senses	Target is **Veiled** until the end of next round: advantage on defense rolls and on its next attack.
Link	Mind	Target and up to Rank other allies within 30 ft get advantage on their next d20 roll before the end of next round.

4.2.3 Twists (optional, +1 Flux each)

A Surge can carry **one Twist** (two **different** Twists from Rank 3). Each Twist adds **+1 Flux** to its cost. Twists are always available.

Twist	Works with	Effect
Chain	Strike, Bolt	After resolving, repeat it against a second target within 15 ft of the first for half damage.
Linger	Burst, Wave, Pulse	The area stays until the end of next round. An enemy that enters it or starts its turn there takes 2 × Rank damage and the rider (no roll).
Leech	Any damage	Regain HP equal to half the damage dealt to one target.
Overcharge	Any damage	+2 damage dice.
Sure	Any	Roll the attack with advantage, or Infuse one extra ally.
Reach	Any	Double range or area size. Strike reaches 15 ft.
Hush	Any	Silent and invisible in origin; using it doesn't reveal you or break stealth.

> **Budget check.** A plain weapon hit at level 1 averages ~7.5 damage (1d8 + 3). A Bolt Surge averages ~12 *and* applies a condition. At level 7 (Rank 4, primary +8) a weapon hit is ~26 and a Bolt Surge ~30.5 plus a rider. That's the trade: Surges are stronger, but you don't choose which ones you get (except your Signatures), and each one pushes you toward Overload.

4.3 The Sequence

Your **Sequence** is a numbered list of your Surges. Its size is your **Sequence die**. The die only grows twice after level 2, when you **Evolve**:

Level	1	2–3	4–6 (Evolution I)	7–10 (Evolution II)
Sequence die	d4	d6	**d8**	**d12**
Surges known	level + 2 (3 at level 1, 12 at level 10)			
Prime	2	2	**3**	**4**
Signature Surges	—	—	**1**	**2**
Wild slots	1	2, then 1	2, 1, 0	3, 2, 1, 0

Write your Surges in slots 1, 2, 3... Any slot without a Surge is **Wild** (see below). Right after each Evolution your new body offers powers you don't understand yet (extra Wild slots). Then you fill them in, one per level, until your Sequence is full at levels 6 and 10.

You can leave a slot Wild on purpose. When you gain a level, you may **rewrite** one known Surge into a different build.

4.4 Priming

At the start of each combat (after initiative), each freelancer rolls their **Sequence die** once per point of **Prime**. Each result's Surge is **Primed**: ready to Unleash this fight. Mark them.

- **Doubles:** if two dice show the same Surge, it is Primed once and **Amped**: it costs **0 Flux** when Unleashed.
- **Wild:** if a die shows a Wild slot, roll on the **Wild Surge table** right away. That result is Primed. Each Wild die rolls separately; Wild results never count as doubles.

- **Juice:** spend 1 Juice to set one Sequence die to any result before you check for doubles.
- **Chrome Firmware** (see Augment Trees) lets you swap one Primed Surge after rolling.

Unused Primed Surges fade when combat ends.

4.5 Unleashing

Unleash is an Action. Choose a Primed Surge, pay its **Flux** (1 + 1 per Twist; 0 if Amped), and resolve it. It is no longer Primed.

Missed? If a Strike or Bolt Surge misses, the Flux is still paid but the Surge **stays Primed** (still Amped, if it was). Your body tried; it'll try again.

4.6 Churning

Churn is a Quick action: gain **1 Flux** and roll your Sequence die once; that Surge is Primed (doubles with an already Primed Surge make it Amped). You **can't Churn on a turn you Unleash** (before or after); a Misfire's free Churn is the only exception. You can't hold more Primed Surges than **Prime + 1** (Signature Surges don't count); if you would, choose which to drop.

4.7 Signature Surges

At **Evolution I** (level 4) you gain one **Signature Surge**, and at **Evolution II** (level 7) a second. These are the powers your evolved body was built around.

- **Build** each from your parts like any Surge, with the Twists your Rank allows, and write it in a **Signature box**, not on the Sequence. It doesn't count toward Surges known, Prime, or the Primed maximum.
- **Always ready:** it's Primed at the start of every combat. When you Unleash it, it is Primed again at the start of your next turn, so you can Unleash each Signature **once per round**.
- **Cost:** its normal Flux (1 + 1 per Twist). Doubles can't Amp it. Only Emergence (its first use) and Final Form make it free. Firmware can't swap it.
- **Missed** Strike or Bolt Signatures are simply ready again next turn.
- When you level up (from level 5), you may **rebuild** one Signature Surge.

> **Why it's fair:** you still get one Action a turn, and every Unleash costs Flux. A freelancer who Unleashes a Signature every round Overloads about once every two fights, unless they have a high Flux Limit (Oracles) or take a turn off to swing a weapon.

4.8 Surges Outside Combat

In any tense scene where the GM calls for initiative-style timing (a chase, a heist gone loud), Surges work the same way. In calm scenes you can't Prime; the Mutagen only answers when you're afraid.

4.9 Wild Surge Table (d12)

When a Wild slot is Primed, roll here. Unless it says otherwise, it costs 1 Flux to Unleash like any Surge.

d12	Wild Surge
1	**Misfire.** Your body sputters. This slot isn't Primed; instead, immediately Churn once for free (no Flux, no action).
2	**Spore Bloom.** Burst + Toxin with +2 dice, centred on **you** (you're unaffected). Allies in it roll Dodge.
3	**Arc Storm.** Bolt + Shock that hits up to three targets at full damage. You are Dazed afterward.
4	**Hardening.** Shell on you and every ally within 10 ft. Your speed is 0 until your next turn.
5	**Blood Price.** Strike + Kinetic with +2 more dice. You take Rank d6 damage (ignores Armor).
6	**Echo.** Unleash a copy of any Surge an ally currently has Primed (it stays Primed for them).
7	**Mitosis.** A shuddering copy of you appears adjacent. It acts on your turn (Move + one weapon attack, using your numbers). When an enemy attacks it, you roll Dodge for it; any failure destroys it. It melts at the end of combat.
8	**Phase Step.** Teleport up to 60 ft, then Strike + Kinetic a creature next to you.
9	**Gravity Knot.** Burst with both Quake and Snare riders.
10	**Feedback.** Pulse + Dread with a 20-ft radius. Costs 2 Flux.
11	**Flush.** Costs 0 Flux. Set your Flux to 0 and regain Rank d8 HP.
12	**Perfect Expression.** Unleash it as a Quick action for 0 Flux: Prime any two of your Surges as Amped (this can exceed your Primed maximum).

4.10 Sample Surges

Steal these, rename them, or build your own.

Name	Build	Flux	Notes
Mantis Lunge	Strike + Kinetic	1	The default "hit it really hard"
Acid Spit	Bolt + Corrode	1	Opens a target up for the whole team
Arc Lash	Wave + Shock (line)	1	Dazes a hallway of enemies
Firebloom	Burst + Blaze + Linger	2	A burning zone that controls space
Pin	Strike + Snare	1	Stops a runner cold
Stomp	Pulse + Quake	1	Everything around you falls down
Nightmare	Bolt + Dread (Chutzpah via Mind)	1	Talk-face's attack
Flashbulb	Burst + Glare	1	Blinds the firing squad
Field Dressing	Infuse + Mend	1	Your medic's best friend
Carapace Flex	Infuse + Shell	1	Brace for impact
Overdrive Shot	Infuse + Haste	1	Give the sniper another turn
Vampire Bite	Strike + Toxin + Leech	2	Drink their strength
Ghost Line	Bolt + Kinetic + Hush	2	Silent sniper kill
Hive Whisper	Infuse + Link + Sure	2	Everyone gets advantage

5. Flux & Overload



Every Surge, every Push, every Churn floods your cells (or circuits) with Mutagen. **Flux** measures how close you are to losing control.

5.1 Flux

- Your Flux starts each mission at **0** (Chrome freelancers who skipped Upkeep start higher).
- You **gain** Flux when you:
  - **Unleash** a Surge: 1, +1 per Twist (0 if Amped).
  - **Churn:** 1.
  - **Push** an Augment: 1.
  - Fail your defense against a **Mutagenic** threat's attack: as its stat block says.
- Your **Flux Limit = 4 + Rank + Nerve** (minimum 4; Splice −1). Nerve rises at each Evolution, so your Limit does too: from 4–8 at level 1 to 9–16 at level 7 (one less for a Splice), highest for Oracles and lowest for Sirens.
- **Signature Surges** cost Flux like any Surge. Unleashing one every round is the fastest way to Overload; that's the price of always being ready.
- Flux **drops to 0** when you take a Breather or a Lockdown, and when you Overload.
- Flux never stops you from acting. You can always choose to go over.

5.2 Overload

The moment your Flux goes **above** your Limit, you **Overload**:

1. Take **Rank d6** damage (ignores Armor). Overload damage (including Glitch *Short*) can't drop you below 1 HP; if you're already Down, skip it.

2. Roll **d12** on your Material's table: **Bloom** if all your trees are Bio, **Glitch** if all are Chrome. Splices roll both and pick one.
3. Set your Flux to **0**.

Results last **until the end of your next turn** unless they say otherwise. **Scars** and **Faults** are permanent.

> **Why go over?** Sometimes the fight is worth it. An Overload resets your Flux and the table has a few gifts. Most results hurt, though, and doing it twice in a fight is a good way to end up Down.

5.2.1 Bloom Table (Bio)

d12	Result
1	**Scar.** A permanent, uncontrolled mutation. Roll on the Scar table below.
2	**Seizure.** You fall Prone and are Dazed.
3	**Ravenous.** Disadvantage on checks (not attacks or defenses) until you eat a ration.
4	**Overgrowth.** Your speed is halved until your next Breather.
5	**Red Mist.** On your next turn you must attack the nearest creature, friend or foe.
6	**Fever.** You are Poisoned.
7	**Molt.** Armor −1 until your next Breather, but regain Rank d8 HP now.
8	**Twitch.** One random Surge you know (roll your Sequence die; Wild = nothing) becomes Primed.
9	**Adrenal Flood.** Gain 2 × Rank temporary HP. You are Shaken.
10	**Cocoon.** You are Held (encased) until the end of your next turn, but take no damage until then.
11	**Blossom.** A beautiful permanent change: gain one new Knack describing it (*Bioluminescent*, *Smells Like Rain*...).
12	**Flowering.** One Primed Surge becomes Amped, and gain 1 Juice.

5.2.2 Glitch Table (Chrome)

d12	Result
1	**Fault.** A permanent malfunction. Roll on the Fault table below.
2	**Hard Reboot.** You lose your next Action.
3	**Short.** Take another Rank d6 Shock damage.
4	**Joint Lock.** Your speed is 0.
5	**Targeting Error.** Your next attack targets a random creature in range (the GM picks among friends and foes).
6	**Blackout.** You are Blinded.
7	**Heat Vent.** Every creature within 10 ft of you, ally or enemy, takes Rank d6 Blaze (allies Dodge vs DC 12 + Rank to avoid).
8	**Log Dump.** Numbers scroll past your eyes: you Analyze one enemy for free.
9	**Safe Mode.** +1 Armor until combat ends, but your Surges cost +1 Flux until combat ends.
10	**Overclock Spike.** Take an extra Action on your next turn; you're Dazed after it.
11	**Patch Applied.** Remove one Fault, or if you have none, gain +1 Flux Limit permanently (once ever).
12	**Root Access.** Choose the results of your next Prime or Churn, and gain 1 Juice.

5.3 Scars and Faults (d6)

Permanent, but survivable. A clinic can remove one for **200 Scrip** between missions.

d6	Bio Scar	Chrome Fault
1	**Weeping Pores.** You leave a trail; disadvantage on stealth checks against smell-trackers.	**Tick.** Your chrome clicks audibly; disadvantage on stealth checks against hearing.
2	**Wrong Face.** Unaugmented people are unsettled; disadvantage on Chutzpah checks to charm them (advantage to intimidate).	**Static Voice.** Same, but through a speaker grille.
3	**Hollow Bones.** −2 Max HP per Rank, +5 ft speed.	**Drained Cell.** −1 Flux Limit, +1 Armor (heavier shielding).
4	**Second Mouth.** It whispers. Once per session, the GM tells you something true you'd rather not know.	**Ghost Process.** Once per session, the GM controls one of your Reactions.
5	**Brittle Shell.** Armor −1, but Regenerate (Glands) works for you even if you don't have it, at half value.	**Sticky Relay.** The highest slot on your Sequence is always Wild, so you know one Surge fewer than the level table says (if your Sequence was full, erase the Surge in that slot).
6	**Hunger for Change.** Gain +1 Flux at the start of every combat. Your first Surge each combat is Amped.	**Feedback Loop.** Gain +1 Flux at the start of every combat. Your first Surge each combat is Amped.

5.4 Last Gasp

Once per Lockdown, when you would drop to 0 HP, you may **Overload on purpose** instead: skip the damage step, roll on your table, and stay at **1 HP**. Your body refuses to die, and pays for it.

5.5 Mutagenic Threats

Some enemies are **Mutagenic** (see Threats). When you fail your defense against their attack, you also gain the listed Flux (a successful defense against an Area keeps it out, even though you take half damage). This is how the city slowly changes you.

6. Combat

Combat is fast because the GM barely rolls. Players attack enemies' **Guard**; players defend against enemies' **TN**. All the enemies act in one phase, one after another, so the GM runs them in a single quick sweep.

6.1 Starting a Fight

1. **Who goes first?**
   - If the freelancers start it (ambush, first shot), **players go first**.
   - If enemies ambush, the group makes a **Nerve** group check (notice) vs the enemies' highest TN. Failure: enemies take a free Enemy Phase first; after it, players go first.
   - Otherwise, the group makes a **Moxie** group check vs the enemies' highest TN. Success: players go first. Failure: enemies go first.
2. **Prime.** Every freelancer rolls their Sequence dice (Surges).
3. Run rounds.

6.2 The Round

Each round has two phases:

1. **Player Phase.** Players take turns in any order they agree on, one at a time. A player can **wait** and go later in the phase, as long as they haven't done anything yet this turn.
2. **Enemy Phase.** Every enemy gets a **Move and one action** (usually an attack; Elites attack twice, Bosses see Threats). The GM resolves the enemies one at a time, in any order; targeted players roll defense. At the start of each enemy's turn, first resolve what happens "at the start of its turn": Burning, Regenerating, and a Boss ending one condition on itself.

Then the next round starts. If enemies went first, the round is Enemy Phase then Player Phase.

Durations. "Until the end of its next turn" means the end of that creature's next turn. For enemies, their turn is the Enemy Phase, so a condition you put on an enemy during the Player Phase lasts through the coming Enemy Phase and ends when that phase ends. **"Until the end of next round"** means through the whole round after the current one.

Bosses' Interrupts. A Boss also gets an **Interrupt**: one action (no Move) right after any player's turn, once per round (Threats).

6.3 Your Turn

On your turn you get a **Move**, an **Action**, and a **Quick action**, in any order. You also get **one Reaction** per round (it refreshes at the start of your turn; the Skitter's Mantis Reflex gives two).

Move. Up to your speed (30 ft; 6 squares on a grid). You can split it around your Action. Climbing, swimming, crawling, and difficult terrain cost double. Standing from Prone costs half your speed.

6.3.1 Actions

Action	What it does
Attack	Weapon or natural attack: d20 + stat + Rank vs Guard. Damage = **Rank × weapon die + stat**.
Unleash	Use a Primed Surge or a Signature Surge (Chapter 4).
Dash	Move again.
Brace	Advantage on all defense rolls until your next turn.
Help	An ally within 30 ft gets advantage on their next roll before your next turn. Describe how.
Patch	Use a Medkit charge on a creature you touch: Gumption check, DC 10. Success: it regains **Rank d6 + Gumption** HP (a Down creature stands up). Failure: the charge is still used, but it regains 1 HP.
Analyze	Gumption + Rank vs the TN of a creature you can see within 60 ft. Success: learn its stat block (or one weakness) and it is **Exposed** until the end of its next turn.
Taunt	Chutzpah + Rank vs the TN of a creature you can see within 60 ft. Success: in its next Enemy Phase, it must target you if it can.
Rally	Chutzpah check, DC 13. Success: every ally within 60 ft who can hear you gains **Rank + Chutzpah** temporary HP. Once per combat per ally.
Grapple / Shove	Grit + Rank vs the Guard of a creature in your melee reach. Success: the target is **Held**, or pushed 10 ft, or knocked **Prone** (not Huge).
Other	Hack a door, haul a lever, run a check. If it takes about 6 seconds, it's an Action.

6.3.2 Quick Actions

Draw or stow an item, open a door, drink a stim, speak a few sentences, **Churn**, **Target Lock** (Senses), or anything the rules call Quick.

6.3.3 Reactions

You have **one Reaction** per round. Spend it on:

- **Opportunity Strike:** when an enemy leaves your melee reach, make one melee weapon attack against it.
- Reactions from Augments (Bulwark, Reflex Spike, Threat Sense, Precog, Fortress).

6.3.4 Opportunity Strikes

- **Leaving reach provokes.** When a creature moves out of an enemy's melee reach, that enemy may make one melee attack against it right then (a freelancer attacks with a melee weapon; an enemy uses its melee attack and you defend).
- **One per round.** A freelancer's Opportunity Strike uses their Reaction. Each enemy can make **one Opportunity Strike per round**. A Dazed creature can't make one.
- **Moving carefully:** move at half speed (each 5 ft costs 10 ft; each square costs 2) and you provoke no Opportunity Strikes for that movement.
- Teleporting, being pushed or pulled, and Slipstream never provoke.

6.4 Positioning: Theatre of the Mind or Grid

Mutagen plays equally well with **theatre of the mind** or on a **battle map**. Pick one per table (or per fight). Every distance in the book is in feet; this is how to read it either way.

Distance	Theatre of the mind	Grid (1 square = 5 ft)
Touch, adjacent, melee reach	**Close**	1 square, diagonals included

Distance	Theatre of the mind	Grid (1 square = 5 ft)
Reach 10 ft (Huge, Grapnel, Pole Haft)	Close, or one step away	2 squares
30 ft (one Move, Help, Infuse, Shotgun)	**Near**	6 squares
60 ft (Bolt, Burst, Pistol, Analyze, Taunt, Rally)	**Far**	12 squares
120 ft (Rifle, a Bolt with Reach)	Far	24 squares
Beyond	**Distant**	off the map

6.4.1 Ranges (both ways)

- **Melee reach** is 5 ft (adjacent) unless a feature extends it.
- **Ranged attacks** reach their listed range. You can shoot up to **double** that range with disadvantage, except with Area weapons, grenades and Surges (those stop at their listed range).
- **A shooter next to an enemy is distracted.** Ranged attacks are at disadvantage while an enemy is adjacent to the attacker. When an *enemy* fires a ranged attack while a freelancer is adjacent to it, the target defends with advantage.
- **Line of sight:** you need to see a target to attack it at range or to Analyze, Taunt or Target Lock it. Creatures don't block sight; walls and big obstacles do.
- **Pushes** move the target directly away from you.

6.4.2 Areas (both ways)

An Area hits every creature inside it; each one rolls its own defense (enemies compare your one attack to their Guard).

- **Burst** "N-ft radius" (or "N ft around it"): every creature within N ft of a point. On a grid, a square of N÷5 squares around the point: a 10-ft burst covers 5×5 squares, 20 ft covers 9×9. "Around it" leaves out the creature itself.
- **Cone** N ft: from you, N÷5 squares deep, widening one square on each side per square (a quarter-circle).
- **Line** N ft: from you, N÷5 squares long and one square wide.
- **Walls stop Areas.** A square the centre of the Area can't see is not in it.
- **Allies in your Area:** your Burst and Wave hit allies inside too (they roll Dodge against your attack total; success = half damage, no rider). Pulses, Psychic Scream and anything that says "creatures you choose" hit only who you choose.
- **Who's in it, theatre of the mind:** the GM decides from the fiction. As a guide for a party of four that isn't bunching up or spreading out, a 10-ft Area catches its target and about one in three of the others, 20 ft about half, 30 ft about two in three. Tell the players when they're bunched up.

6.4.3 On a Grid

- **Distance** is the larger of the two gaps (diagonals count as one square).
- **Every creature fills one square**, Huge ones included (or 2×2 if your map has room). You can move through allies but not enemies, and you can't end your move in an occupied square.
- **Walls and big obstacles** block movement, line of sight and Areas (trace a line from centre to centre). Fliers ignore obstacles when moving.
- Summoned creatures appear in free squares next to their summoner.

6.5 Attacking

Roll **d20 + stat + Rank** against the target's **Guard**.

- **Melee:** the stat listed for the weapon in Gear (Grit for heavy hitting, Moxie for finesse; many weapons allow either).
- **Ranged:** Nerve. Long range (up to double, with disadvantage) and shooting with an enemy next to you: see Ranges.
- **Crit** on a natural 20: roll the damage dice twice.

6.6 Defending

When an enemy attacks you, roll **d20 + defense stat + Rank** against its **TN**. The stat block names the defense:

- **Dodge** (Moxie): claws, bullets, spit, anything you can see coming.
- **Endure** (Grit): gas, blasts, disease, crushing grabs.
- **Resist** (Nerve): fear, psychic attacks, hacking your wetware.

Single attacks: success = no damage. **Area** attacks: success = half damage. Failure = full damage plus any rider.

Enemy Opportunity Strikes. If you leave an enemy's melee reach on your turn, it gets a free attack on you right then (you defend; one per enemy per round, above). Move carefully (half speed) to slip away safely.

6.7 Damage

- **Armor** reduces each instance of damage by its value (minimum 1). Armor doesn't reduce Psychic damage or anything that "ignores Armor."
- **Resistance** halves damage of a type; **Vulnerability** doubles it.
- **Temporary HP** soaks damage first and doesn't stack (keep the higher). It fades at the end of combat.
- **Cover:** partial cover gives you +2 to defense rolls (and gives enemies +2 Guard). Full cover means you can't be targeted.
- **Damage types:** Kinetic, Blaze, Shock, Toxin, Corrode, Psychic.

6.8 Conditions

All conditions last **until the end of the affected creature's next turn** unless a rule says otherwise. Reapplying a condition refreshes it; it doesn't stack. **Bosses** end one condition on themselves at the start of their turn in every Enemy Phase.

Condition	Effect
Blinded	Can't see. Disadvantage on attacks (a Blinded enemy's targets defend with advantage); attacks against it have advantage (a Blinded player defends with disadvantage).
Burning	Takes **2 × the source's Rank** Blaze damage at the start of its next turn (for enemies: at the start of its turn in the Enemy Phase), then the flames die down. Healing that ends Burning (Mend, Stim Gland) puts it out before it bites.
Dazed	No Reaction or Quick action (so no Opportunity Strikes). A Dazed enemy can't use Specials, and a Dazed Boss gets only one action.

Condition	Effect
Exposed	−2 Guard (enemies) or −2 to defense rolls (players).
Held	Speed 0. Ends early if the holder is moved away, Dazed, or Down.
Poisoned	Deals half damage.
Prone	Melee attacks against it have advantage; ranged attacks against it have disadvantage. Standing costs half speed.
Shaken	Disadvantage on attacks and checks; can't willingly move closer to the source. A Shaken enemy's targets defend with advantage.
Veiled	Advantage on defense rolls and on its next attack.
Down	See below.

> **Enemy advantage → player disadvantage.** Since enemies don't roll, "attacks against a Prone player have advantage" means that player defends with **disadvantage**.

6.9 Going Down

At **0 HP** you are **Down**: fall Prone, drop what you're holding, and you can only crawl 5 ft and speak.

- At the end of each Enemy Phase, roll **Endure (DC 10)**. Failure: mark a **Death mark**. A natural 20: stand up with 1 HP.
- You can still be attacked while Down; you defend normally (Prone: disadvantage against melee). Taking damage while Down marks a Death mark (two on a Crit or failed defense vs a Boss).
- **3 Death marks: you die.**
- Any healing stands you up with that much HP. Death marks clear on a Breather.
- When you go Down, roll on the **Injury** table. Injuries last until your next Lockdown.
- **Last Gasp** (Chapter 5) can keep you up once per Lockdown.
- **If every freelancer is Down or dead, the fight is lost.** The enemies win the scene: the GM decides what they do with the fallen (capture, strip their gear, drag them off as Samples, or leave them for dead with their Endure rolls still running). It's a setback, not automatically the end.

6.9.1 Injury Table (d6)

d6	Injury (until Lockdown)
1	**Cracked Ribs.** −5 Max HP.
2	**Concussion.** Disadvantage on Gumption checks.
3	**Torn Limb.** Disadvantage on attacks with one chosen limb (your choice: arms or legs → speed −10 ft instead).
4	**Ruptured Gland / Fried Port.** Your Flux Limit is −2.
5	**Shell Shock.** Disadvantage on Resist.
6	**Lucky Break.** Just a scar. No effect.

6.10 Ending a Fight

Combat ends when one side is gone, flees, or gives up. Unused Primed Surges fade, temporary HP fades, and Bio freelancers' **Knit** heals them (a Down freelancer healed this way gets up). Enemies at half HP or less with a sense of self-preservation usually try to flee or surrender; at the GM's call,

a Chutzpah check can make them.

7. Advancement

One mission, one level. When the party completes a GRAFT contract (successfully or not, as long as they survive and learn something), everyone gains a level. A full campaign is **10 missions**: levels 1 to 10, with the finale played at level 10. For shorter games, start at level 4 (freshly Evolved) or level 7.

7.1 Level Table

Level	Rank	Stage	Stats (prim / sec / tert / dumps)	Nodes: primary + sec/tert (+ Evolution)	Surges known	Seq. die	Prime	Signatures	Other
1	1	Base	+3 / +2 / +1 / +0, −1	3 + 3 = **6**	3	d4	2	—	3 Knacks
2	1	Base		4 + 4 = 8	4	d6	2	—	
3	2	Base		5 + 5 = 10	5	d6	2	—	+1 Knack
4	2	**Evolution I**	**+5 / +3 / +2 / +1, +0**	6 + 6 (+1) = **13**	6	**d8**	**3**	**1**	Evolution node; Tier II opens
5	3	Evolution I		7 + 7 (+1) = 15	7	d8	3	1	Plating → +2 Armor; 2 Twists per Surge
6	3	Evolution I		8 + 8 (+1) = 17	8	d8	3	1	+1 Knack
7	4	**Evolution II**	**+8 / +4 / +3 / +2, +1**	9 + 9 (+2) = **20**	9	**d12**	**4**	**2**	Evolution node; **Apex** opens
8	4	Evolution II		10 + 10 (+2) = 22	10	d12	4	2	Primary tree full
9	5	Evolution II		10 + 12 (+2) = 24	11	d12	4	2	+1 Knack; primary pick overflows
10	5	**Final**		10 + 14 (+2) = **26**	12	d12	4	2	**Final Form**

"Primary + sec/tert" counts nodes in your primary tree plus nodes in your secondary and tertiary trees combined. From level 9, the primary pick overflows into the secondary or tertiary tree.

7.2 Each Level

1. **+5 Max HP** (+2 more with Hide: Thick). Recalculate HP whenever Grit changes.
2. **+1 primary-tree node** (automatic; you choose which) **and +1 node in your secondary or tertiary tree** (chapter 3).
3. **+1 Surge** (build it from your parts). You may also **rewrite** one existing Surge, and from level 5 **rebuild** one Signature Surge.
4. Recalculate Rank, Flux Limit, and defenses.
5. Optionally **respec** one Augment node.

At level 4 and level 7: Evolve (chapter 2A). Raise your stats to the new stage, add +1 Prime, step up the Sequence die, build a Signature Surge, and write in your Form's Evolution node. You **Emerge** on screen in the next mission's first fight.

There are no stat boosts. Stats rise only at the Evolutions.

Final Form (level 10): your third and last stage. Once per Lockdown, at the start of a combat, enter Final Form until it ends: **primary stat +2**, **Prime two extra Surges**, and **every Surge you Unleash is Amped** (Signatures too).

7.3 Samples

Bosses and some Elites carry a **Sample**: a piece of their mutated biology or chrome. After defeating one, a freelancer can harvest it with a Gumption check (DC = its TN). Between missions, a GRAFT clinic can splice it into you **for 100 Scrip**:

- It becomes a new Surge in one of your **Wild slots**. It may use the Boss's signature Shape and Effect even if you haven't unlocked them.
- If you have no Wild slots, it replaces a Surge you know.

GRAFT technically owns all Samples. Selling one on the black market pays 300 Scrip × its Threat level and is a great way to get a mission about it.

7.4 Pay

GRAFT pays **200 + (100 × mission level) Scrip** per freelancer on completion (300 at level 1), plus bonuses the GM sets. See Gear for prices.

7.5 Respec and Clinics

Installing nodes happens off-screen at a clinic between missions. Removing a Scar or Fault costs 200 Scrip (a Clinic Rat pays half; see Origins).

8. Gear



Gear in Mutagen is **modular**: every weapon is a **Frame** plus up to **one Mod**. Damage always scales with your Rank, so a good knife stays useful all campaign.

Money is **Scrip** (GRAFT company credit, accepted almost everywhere in Halcyon).

8.1 Weapons

Damage = Rank × die + attack stat. A level 5 Juggernaut (Rank 3, Grit +5 after Evolution I) with a Heavy weapon deals 3d10+5.

8.1.1 Frames

Frame	Die	Stat	Range	Hands	Notes	Cost
Unarmed	d4	Grit	Melee	—	Always available	—
Light melee (knife, baton, hatchet)	d6	Moxie or Grit	Melee / thrown 20 ft	1	Concealable	15
Standard melee (machete, bat, blade)	d8	Grit or Moxie	Melee	1		30
Heavy melee (sledge, chainsaw, pipe-axe)	d10	Grit	Melee	2		40
Natural weapons	d8	Grit or Moxie	Melee	—	From Limbs Root; can't be disarmed	node
Pistol	d6	Nerve	60 ft	1	Concealable	40
Rifle	d8	Nerve	120 ft	2		80
Shotgun	d10	Nerve	30 ft	2	Loud	60
Launcher	d6	Nerve	90 ft	2	**Area** (10-ft radius); 3 shots per mission	150

Area weapons work like area Surges: one attack, compare to each Guard, half damage on a miss. They can't fire at long range. **Ranges** are in feet; on a grid divide by 5 (Pistol 12 squares, Rifle 24, Shotgun 6, Launcher 18, thrown 4). Other ranged weapons can shoot to double their range with disadvantage (Ranges).

8.1.2 Mods (one per weapon, 100 Scrip each)

Mod	Effect
Keen Edge / Hollow-point	Crit on 19–20. (Crit ranges don't stack; use the widest.)
Shock Coil	Damage becomes Shock; on a Crit, the target is Dazed.
Incendiary	Damage becomes Blaze; on a Crit, the target is Burning.
Venom Channel	Damage becomes Toxin; on a Crit, the target is Poisoned.
Acid Etch	Damage becomes Corrode; on a Crit, the target is Exposed.
Weighted	On a Crit, the target is knocked Prone (not Huge).
Suppressor	Silent. Shooting doesn't reveal your position.
Scope	Double range; ignore partial cover.
Pole Haft	Melee reach 10 ft.
Smart-Link	+1 to attack rolls. Counts as Chrome (needs Upkeep: 25 Scrip per mission).

8.2 Armor

Armor reduces each hit by its value. **Total Armor (gear + Augments) maxes at 4** (5 with Hide's *Unbreakable,* 6 with the Juggernaut's *Siege Hide*). You wear one armor, Light *or* Heavy, plus an optional Shield.

Armor	Armor	Notes	Cost
Light (padded jacket, scavenged plates)	1	—	30
Heavy (riot plating, hazmat shell)	2	Speed −5 ft; disadvantage on stealth	120
Shield (door, riot shield)	+1	Uses one hand	40

8.3 Kit

Item	Effect	Cost
Medkit	3 charges for the Patch action	25
Stim	*Quick:* regain Rank d6 HP	30
Damper	*Quick:* lose 2 Flux. One per combat.	50
Frag grenade	*Action:* Nerve attack, 10-ft radius within 30 ft, Rank d6 Kinetic, **Area**	40
Flashbang	As frag, but no damage; hit creatures are **Blinded**	40
EMP grenade	As frag, but Shock; machines hit are **Dazed** (Chrome freelancers in it defend with disadvantage)	60
Gas mask	Advantage on Endure against gas and spores	20
Breach kit	Advantage on checks to force doors and locks	30
Hack deck	Required for hacking checks without the Mind tree	50
Scanner	Detects heat, motion, and Mutagen within 60 ft	50
Grapnel & 50 ft line	Climbing aid	10

Item	Effect	Cost
Ration	A day of food; cures **Ravenous**	5
Clinic visit	Remove a Scar or Fault	200
Sample splice	Install a Sample as a Surge (Advancement)	100

8.4 Starting Kits

Every kit includes: **Light armor**, GRAFT ID, radio, flashlight, 2 rations, 1 Damper.

Kit	Contents
Bruiser	Heavy melee weapon, Medkit, Grapnel
Gunhand	Rifle or Shotgun, Pistol, Frag grenade
Sneak	Two Light melee weapons, Pistol with Suppressor, Breach kit
Medic	Pistol, Standard melee weapon, 2 Medkits, 2 Stims
Face	Concealed Pistol, Light melee weapon, Hack deck, Flashbang, +50 Scrip
Wardrunner	Standard melee weapon, Shotgun, Gas mask, Scanner

Part Two: Running Mutagen

For the Game Master: running missions, building fair fights from the threat tables, and a first mission to play tonight.

9. Running the Game

This chapter is for the GM. Everything a player needs is in chapters 1–8.

9.1 Your Job

1. **Describe Halcyon** vividly and briefly: smell, sound, one weird detail.
2. **Ask questions** and use the answers. *"Vex, which gang tattooed you?"*
3. **Call for rolls only when failure is interesting.** Otherwise say yes.
4. **Make failures move the story:** fail, succeed at a cost, or things get worse. Never "nothing happens."
5. **Hand out Juice** generously; roughly one per player per session, more for great moments.

9.2 Setting DCs

Pick the DC from the Core Rules table: **13 when unsure.** Add advantage or disadvantage for circumstances instead of fiddling with numbers. If an enemy is opposing the check directly, use its **TN**.

9.3 Running the Enemy Phase

- Declare all enemy actions at once: *"The two Cleaners fire at Vex and Juno; the Drain Beast grabs Ozzie."*
- Players roll their defenses; you just read out Damage and riders.
- Mooks and Soldiers act simply. Elites and Bosses should feel smart: focus the weak, punish clumping, flee when beaten.
- **Spread attacks** unless the fiction says otherwise. Focusing one player every round is how you get a death in a Standard fight.
- Let the fiction override the grid: a Brute can smash a wall, a Skirmisher can jump down a stairwell.
- **Area attacks catch whoever is inside.** Be honest about positions. Heavies (big Area, Engulf) are built to punish a bunched-up party; tell players that spreading out is the counter, and don't line them up in a corridor for the Heavy unless they walked into it.
- **Packs focus.** Pack, Flanker and Overwhelm creatures gang up on one freelancer; that's their whole point. Everyone else should still spread attacks.
- **Default tactics** (what the arcade's enemies do, and a good baseline for yours):
  - Area attackers aim where they catch the most freelancers and the fewest friends; Bulky ones won't fire into their own allies.
  - Melee enemies close in and flank; ranged enemies stay out of melee reach and shoot.
  - Anything with no target in reach Dashes toward one.
  - Elites, Bosses and Hunters go for the freelancer with the lowest HP about half the time; everyone else picks a target that makes sense in the fiction.
  - A Taunted enemy goes for its taunter if it can.
  - Bosses use their Interrupt on the first good opening each round and summon when their minions are thin.

9.4 Missions

GRAFT contracts follow a simple shape. Each is about one session.

1. **Brief.** A GRAFT handler explains the job and the pay. Players ask questions, buy gear.
2. **Approach.** Getting in: travel, a social obstacle, or a skill challenge.
3. **Trouble.** One or two fights or hazards. Something is not what the brief said.
4. **Heart.** The objective: a boss, a choice, a sample, a person.
5. **Out.** Escape, consequences, a Breather if earned.
6. **Debrief.** Get paid, level up, downtime.

9.4.1 The Spill Clock

Give each mission a **6-segment clock**. Tick it when players dawdle, make noise, Overload, or fail a roll badly. When it fills, the situation escalates: reinforcements, a flood, a Cleaner squad, the building collapses. Then reset it. Show it to the players; it makes them hurry.

9.4.2 Skill Challenges

For a chase, a hack, or a climb, ask for **3 successes before 3 failures** (Standard DC). Each player says how they help and picks a stat. Each failure costs something: HP (T-level Damage), a tick on the Spill Clock, or lost gear.

9.5 Downtime (between missions)

Each freelancer picks **one**:

- **Clinic:** install your new node, splice a Sample, remove a Scar or Fault, or (at levels 4 and 7) go through a supervised **Chrysalis**.
- **Side Gig:** earn 50 × level Scrip.
- **Dig:** learn a secret about the next mission (the GM answers one question truthfully).
- **Rest:** clear all Injuries and gain 1 Juice at the start of next session.
- **Bond:** spend time with a contact; they'll do you a favour on the next mission.

9.6 Evolution at the Table

Evolutions (levels 4 and 7) are the biggest moments in a freelancer's life. Make them land.

- **Seed it.** In the mission before, describe symptoms: an itch under the plating, a second heartbeat, a voice in the wiring, clothes that don't fit.
- **Chrysalis (optional downtime scene).** At the debrief where someone reaches level 4 or 7, play one short scene of the change starting: a cocoon in a flooded basement (Bio), or an emergency overhaul on a clinic table while GRAFT techs argue (Chrome). Ask the player one question: *"What do you lose?"* (a face, a voice, a fear, a friend's trust). Write it down; it's a hook.
- **Emergence.** In the next mission's first fight, the player Emerges at the start of their first turn (chapter 2A): temporary HP, nearby enemies Shaken, a free Signature Surge. Give them the spotlight. Describe enemies backing away.
- **Let them win big once.** The first mission after an Evolution should feel like a victory lap. Then raise the stakes (see below).
- **Different speeds.** Everyone Evolves at the same level, so the whole party spikes together. Lean into it: the Spill Clock, GRAFT and the factions all *notice* evolved freelancers.

9.7 Difficulty Across the Campaign

Every enemy has a **Boss Rating** (one of it is a fair fight for 4 level-N freelancers) and a **Minion Rating** (four of it are). Build fights with the unit budget in Threats: **one unit per freelancer is a Hard (fair) fight**, ×½ Easy, ×¾ Standard, ×1¼ Deadly. The ratings already account for each level, including the Evolutions, so the same budget works from level 1 to 10.

What the Evolutions change is **last stage's monsters**. A creature rated in the previous stage falls apart against freshly Evolved freelancers (four MR 3 creatures: Hard at level 3, Easy at level 4), and one rated in the next stage is twice as dangerous as its number suggests.

Party level	Plan	What to do
1–3 (Base)	Standard fights, one Hard per mission	Downs happen; Rats and Pickers teach Pack tactics, the Drain Beast and Boiler Hulk teach spreading out
4 (just Evolved)	A victory lap	Bring back level-3 enemies (they're Easy now), then one Hard fight with Evolution I creatures so the new body has something to push against
5–6	Hard set pieces	Mix a Heavy centrepiece with a Pack; add Purgers and enemies that hit weak defenses (Resist for Sirens, Endure for Oracles)
7 (Evolved again)	A victory lap with bigger monsters	Level-6 enemies are Easy now; open with them, then show a Feral Evolved or a Gutter Leviathan
8–10	Hard and Deadly fights; the finale should be Deadly	Bosses whose Shift lands after Final Form is spent; Seraph Gunships over open ground

Between Breathers: a fully rested party can take about **one Hard fight plus one Standard fight**, or three Standard fights, before it needs one (an estimate from HP lost per fight; the sims only test fully rested parties). The ratings assume full HP and Flux 0, so a tired party should face less.

Checks don't scale. A DC 16 door stays DC 16. At high level, threaten what Forms are *bad* at (ask the Juggernaut for a Gumption check, the Oracle to win an arm-wrestle), and put Extreme (19), Mutant (22), Monstrous (25) and Mythic (28) obstacles in the way. A level 7 primary stat of +8 makes Hard checks routine; that's the point of Evolving.

9.8 Rewards

- **Levels:** one per mission (Advancement).
- **Scrip:** 200 + (100 × mission level) each, plus bonuses for style or recovered Samples.
- **Samples:** from Bosses and some Elites.
- **Juice:** in the moment.

9.9 Factions at a Glance

Faction	Wants	Will pay for	Will kill for
GRAFT	Contain the Spill cheaply	Samples, clean reports	Leaked internal memos
Ostrander Remnant	Erase evidence, retake the city	Silence, stolen Samples	Proof of what caused the Spill
Children of the Bloom	Spread the change	Converts, rare mutations	Antimutagen stockpiles
Scrapjacks	Parts, any parts	Rare chrome	Your arm

Faction	Wants	Will pay for	Will kill for
Drowned Wards	To be left alone, clean water	Protection, medicine	Anyone who brings the Spill home

9.10 Mission Generator (roll d6 four times)

d6	Client	Job	Location	Twist
1	GRAFT handler	Recover a lost Sample	Flooded subway	The target is a person
2	Ward council	Kill a creature	Ostrander lab floor	A rival crew is here too
3	Ostrander defector	Escort someone out	Bloom cathedral (old mall)	The client is lying
4	Bloom priest	Steal antimutagen	Scrapjack junk-fortress	The Spill Clock starts at 3
5	Scrapjack boss	Fix or sabotage a pump	Arcology root levels	The creature is protecting something
6	Anonymous message	Find out why people are vanishing	Rooftop farms	Someone in the party is the real target

9.11 Pacing Guidelines

- **Fights:** 2–3 per mission. One should be Hard. The boss can be Deadly if the players found a way to soften it. Size every fight with the encounter budget, and scale Bosses for party size (Threats §6).
- **Breathers:** let the party take them, but make the clock tick.
- **Surges:** encourage them. If a player never Unleashes, ask what their body is doing. Surges are the fun.
- **Overload:** describe it gleefully, never as a punishment. It's the setting coming through the character.

9.12 Safety

Body horror can hit hard. Before play, agree as a table what's off-limits (lines) and what should happen off-screen (veils). Anyone can pause a scene, no questions asked.

9.13 Rulings Log

Keep a list of rulings at the table. If one should become a permanent rule, write it into your house rules, and if you think every table should have it, send it to the designers as an open question.

10. Threats



Every enemy is built from three parts: **Threat level (T)**, **Role** and **Traits**. Every enemy also carries two ratings that tell you how to use it: a **Boss Rating** and a **Minion Rating**. You can build a new enemy in a few minutes, or read one off the roster below.

10.1 Ratings: BR and MR

- **Boss Rating (BR N): one** of this creature, alone, is a fair fight for **4 fully rested level-N freelancers**.
- **Minion Rating (MR N): four** of this creature are a fair fight for **4 fully rested level-N freelancers**.

A fair fight means, for a fully rested party (full HP, Flux 0, kit full):

Measure	Fair band	Typical at the rating
Party wins	**90%+**	93–99%
At least one freelancer goes Down	**40–60%** (50% target)	40–55% (Bosses 25–35%: their fights are long, so death risk sets the rating)
Anyone dies	**5% or less**	0–5%
Rounds	**3–7**	2–6
Party HP lost	25–50%	30–45%

A creature's rating is the lowest party level at which its fight stays inside *all* of the first three limits. Ratings come from simulated fights with real builder characters of every Form (`tools/encounter_sim.py`, 1,000 fights per level; see `Current_Work.md`, *Enemy Calibration*). **<1** means it is never a fair fight in that use even at level 1 (one Spill Rat). **10+** means no level-10 party can take it in that use (four Feral Evolved).

Read the gap. MR − BR says how a creature wants to be used:

- **About 3** (Generalists): fine alone at its BR or in a group at its MR.
- **2 or less: Heavies.** Big Area attacks make them deadly alone, and especially against big or bunched-up parties; in a crowd they get in each other's way (Bulky, Friendly fire, Interference, Territorial). Use one as a centrepiece.
- **4 or more: Packs.** Pack, Flanker, Overwhelm, Crowd, Linked and Frenzy only work with friends. One is a speed bump; four are a fight.

10.2 Threat Level

T runs 1–10. It sets the numbers; the ratings tell you who it's for.

T	Guard	TN	HP	Damage	Bonus
1	12	13	28	10	2
2	13	13	30	11	2
3	14	14	38	16	3
4	14	16	62	25	5
5	15	17	74	29	6
6	16	18	78	30	6
7	17	20	150	46	9
8	18	21	158	47	9
9	19	22	162	48	10
10	20	23	168	50	10

Beyond T10: +1 Guard, +1 TN, +8 HP and +4 Damage per T. Round role multipliers to the nearest whole number.

- **Guard** is what players **attack** against. **TN** is the **Attack DC** players **defend** against, and the DC for checks that oppose the creature directly (Taunt, Analyze, Puppet).
- **Damage** is fixed, no rolling. Area attacks deal it to everyone caught who fails (half to those who succeed). **Bonus** is the unit for Traits (about ⅕ of Damage).
- **Why the jumps at T4 and T7?** Freelancers Evolve at levels 4 and 7 and roughly double in power. The table jumps with them, so a T-N Soldier stays a fair fight at level N. The Evolution still lands hard: **last stage's monsters fall apart** (four MR 3 creatures, a Hard fight at level 3, are an Easy fight at level 4).
- **Hits are big.** A failed defense against a same-T Soldier costs about ⅔ of an average freelancer's HP. Defenses succeed about half the time, Brace and cover matter, and healing between hits matters more.

10.3 Role

Role	Guard	HP	Damage	Actions	Typical BR	Typical MR
Mook	−1	×¼	×½	1	T − 5	T − 3
Soldier	±0	×1	×1	1	T − 3	**T**
Skirmisher	+1	×¾	×1	1; speed 40, moving after its attack never provokes	T − 3	T
Artillery	±0	×¾	×¾	1; attacks are Area (10 ft) at 90 ft	T − 3	T + 1

Role	Guard	HP	Damage	Actions	Typical BR	Typical MR
Controller	±0	×1	×½	1; every attack carries a rider	T − 4	T − 2
Brute	−1	×2	×1½	1; usually Huge	T − 2	T + 3
Elite	±0	×2	×1	2 attacks	T − 2	T + 3
Heavy (a Brute with the Heavy package, §4)	−1	×2	×1½ Area	1	T + 1	T + 2
Boss	+1	×1 **per freelancer**	×1 for 4 freelancers (×¼ per freelancer)	1 + one **Interrupt** (one action, no Move, right after any player's turn, once per round); ends one condition on itself at the start of its turn each Enemy Phase; **Shift** at half HP	**T + 1**	T + 4

Typical ratings are measured at T2, T5 and T8 with no Traits (`tools/sim_results/09_builder_traits.md`). A Soldier's MR is its T: that's what the table is calibrated on.

10.4 Traits

Pick 1–3. **ΔBR / ΔMR** is how much each Trait moves the ratings (measured; ½ = half a rating step). Traits marked 0 / 0 change how a fight *feels* (Flux, Surges, positioning) more than how dangerous it is.

Group Traits (they only work with friends; this is what makes a Pack):

Trait	Effect	ΔBR	ΔMR
Pack	+1 TN and +Bonus damage for each earlier attack by a Pack ally on the same target this round (max +3 TN / +3 Bonus)	0	**+1**
Flanker	Attacks with advantage (the target defends with disadvantage) while another Flanker is fighting (on a grid: while another Flanker is adjacent to the same target)	0	**+1**
Overwhelm	When a freelancer is attacked by a third Overwhelm creature in one round, they are Prone and Held	0	+½
Crowd	+Bonus ÷ 2 damage per other enemy fighting (on a grid: within 10 ft of the target) (max ×3)	0	+½
Linked	Damage to one Linked creature is split evenly among all Linked creatures alive	0	+½
Frenzy	+Bonus damage per ally killed this fight (max +3 Bonus)	0	+½
Leader	Other enemies deal +Bonus damage	0	+½
Mender	Instead of attacking, heals the most-hurt non-Mook ally within 30 ft below 60% HP for ¼ of the T row's HP	0	0
Shield Wall	+1 Guard per other Shield Wall ally fighting (max +2, Mooks +3)	0	0
Explosive	When it dies, everything within 10 ft takes ½ its Damage (**Area**, Endure)	0	+½

Heavy package and its horde penalties (what makes a Heavy):

Trait	Effect	ΔBR	ΔMR
Heavy	Its main attack is an **Area** (20 ft around it or a 20-ft burst; 30 ft for the biggest) at ×1 of its Damage, **Recharge 4–6** (or *skips its next Enemy Phase* after using it); its other attack is Single at ×0.4	+1	**+4**
Engulf +X	The Area attack deals +X (2 × Bonus) to everyone caught for each freelancer caught beyond the first (max +2X)	(in Heavy)	(in Heavy)

Trait	Effect	ΔBR	ΔMR
Friendly fire	The Area attack also hits its allies in the area	(in Heavy)	(in Heavy)
Apex	While it is the only enemy standing: +2 TN and ×1½ Damage (Engulf is added after)	**+1½**	+½
Bulky	Won't catch its friends: before using an Area attack, roll a d6 for each non-Mook ally fighting; on any 1–3 it uses its Single attack instead. On a grid, skip the dice: it uses its Single attack whenever its Area would catch a non-Mook ally	0	**−4**
Interference	Only one Interference creature can use an Area attack each Enemy Phase	0	0 to −½
Territorial	While a rival of its kind is within 15 ft, on d6 1–4 it attacks the rival instead	0	about −1

Every Heavy needs at least one horde penalty (Bulky, Interference or Territorial). Without one, four Heavies are a massacre (MR +4).

Who's caught by an Area? Whoever is inside it. The ratings assume a party of 4 that isn't trying to bunch up or spread out: a 10-ft area catches the target and about 1 in 3 of the others, 20 ft about 1 in 2, 30 ft about 2 in 3, and each freelancer beyond four adds ~8% to those odds. On a battle map Heavies catch more (about 3¼ of 4 freelancers per Area in the arcade's grid fights, even with the party spreading out), so **on a grid a Heavy costs ×1¼ units** (§5). If your table fights shoulder to shoulder in corridors, Heavies hit harder than their rating; tell players that spreading out is the counter.

Solo and utility Traits:

Trait	Effect	ΔBR	ΔMR
Armored X	Armor 1 (T1–3), 2 (T4–6) or 3 (T7+)	0	0
Huge	Reach 10 ft. Can't be knocked Prone or pushed by non-Huge creatures	0	0
Mover	Fly, swim, climb or burrow at its speed	0	0
Mimic	Hidden until it acts; its first attack has advantage	0	+½
Hunter	Half its attacks go to the freelancer with the lowest HP	0	+½
Shielded	The first hit against it each round deals half damage	0	+½
Swarm	Half damage from Single attacks and weapons; double from Area. Can share spaces	0	0
Regenerating X	Regains X HP (T row HP ÷ 10) at the start of each Enemy Phase unless it took Blaze or Corrode damage since its last one	0	0
Damage Gate	The first time it would drop below half HP it stops at half (extra damage is lost) and Shifts	—	—
Cowardly	At half HP or less, it surrenders on a d6 roll of 4–6 at the start of each Enemy Phase	−½	0
Mutagenic X	When a player fails their defense against its attack, they gain X Flux	0	0

Trait	Effect	ΔBR	ΔMR
Purger	Ostrander antimutagen. When a player fails their defense against its attack, they lose one Primed Surge of their choice	0	0
Damper Field	While it lives, every Unleash costs +1 Flux	0	0
Rider (Grabby: Held · Venomous: Poisoned · Corrosive: Exposed · Shocking: Dazed · Fiery: Burning, its Rank = T ÷ 2 round up · Terrifying: uses Resist, Shaken · Blinding: Blinded)	Applies when a player fails the defense roll. Chrome freelancers defend against Shock with disadvantage, as always	0	0
Resistant / Vulnerable (type)	Half / double damage from one damage type	0	0
Sample	Carries a harvestable Sample (Advancement). Describe its Shape + Effect	—	—

ΔMR for group Traits comes from fair-count ratios at L2/L5/L8 (`tools/sim_results/09b_trait_steps.md`); ΔBR and the rest from T5 ratings (`09_builder_traits.md`). The ½-step values for Mimic, Hunter and Shielded are T5-only and rounded down; Territorial and Damage Gate weren't measured on their own (— / about).

Building a new enemy: pick T and Role, read its typical BR/MR, add the Traits' ΔBR/ΔMR, and round. That's within about one step of what the simulator says. If you want it exact, add it to `tools/encounter_roster.py` and run `python3 tools/encounter_sim.py rate "Name"`.

10.5 Building an Encounter

1. Budget. A **Hard** (fair) fight is worth **one unit per freelancer**, with a small correction for very small and very large groups:

Freelancers	2	3	4	5	6
Hard budget (units)	1¾	2¾	**4**	5½	7

2. Difficulty. Multiply the budget:

Difficulty	Budget	What it costs a fully rested party of 4 (sims)
Easy	×½	~10% HP; Downs rare (3–6%)
Standard	×¾	~20% HP; someone goes Down in ~1 fight in 5
Hard	×1 (fair)	~30–40% HP; someone goes Down about half the time; deaths rare
Deadly	×1¼	~50–60% HP; Downs likely; 10–25% chance the party loses or someone dies
Overwhelming	×1½+	The party loses about half the time. Don't, unless running is an option

3. Spend it. A creature's units depend on how far its rating is from the party level:

Rating − party level	−3	−2	−1	0	+1	+2	+3
In a group (use **MR**)	⅓	½	¾	**1**	1½	2	3
As a centrepiece (use **BR**)	1½	2	3	**4**	6	8	11

Value at most **one** creature per encounter by BR (the centrepiece); everything else uses MR. A centrepiece Boss already scaled for the party (§6) is worth the whole Hard budget.

4. Check the stage and the map. Freelancers double in power at each Evolution, so ratings don't carry across one:

- A creature rated in the party's **next** stage (e.g. MR 4 against level 3) counts **double** its units. Avoid more than one.
- A creature rated in the party's **previous** stage (e.g. MR 3 against level 4) counts as **one step lower** than the table says.
- **Playing on a grid?** Count each **Heavy** at **×1¼** its units. Everything else costs the same on a map as off it (the evidence is in §7).

Worked example. Four level-5 freelancers, Hard fight, budget 4: a Glasshide as the centrepiece (BR 5 → 4 units) is the whole fight. Or a Bloom Knight (MR 5 → 1) + two Stitchwork Brood (MR 6 → 1½ each) = 4. For a Standard fight (3 units), take 3 Cleaner Hounds (MR 5 → 1 each).

10.6 Party Size

Use the budget table above, plus three adjustments the sims found:

- **Bosses:** HP ×1 per freelancer and Damage × (freelancers ÷ 4), summoned creatures' Damage too. With 3 freelancers: ×¾; with 5: ×1¼. Without this, a Boss fair for 4 is a near-TPK for 3 (Matriarch: 77% win, 16% death) and a walkover for 5 (13% Down).
- **Heavies vs 5+ freelancers** count **×1½** units. More bodies means more of them inside every Area, and Engulf punishes it: against 5 a Heavy's ratings drop only ~½–¾, other creatures' drop ~1.
- **Quick shift:** if you'd rather move ratings than budgets, a creature's BR and MR are about **+1 against 3 freelancers, −1 against 5** (+2 / −1½ for 2 / 6). Heavies: +1 / −½ to −¾ (as minions vs 3: only +½).

10.7 At the Table

- **From Evolution II, lone big targets melt.** Four L7 freelancers can deal 150+ damage a round. Elites and Bosses rated for them already account for that, but anything rated in the previous stage dies before it acts. Use the stage rule above.
- **Heavies want room; Packs want company.** Put a Heavy in an open hall with the party bunched at a chokepoint and it lives up to its BR. Put four Rats on one freelancer and they live up to their MR.
- **Final Form** (level 10) turns one fight per Lockdown into a rout. The ratings assume it's off. Save the finale's real threat for the Boss's Shift.
- **On a battle map** the budgets hold, except for Heavies. Book-budget Hard fights played on a grid in the arcade engine (1,200 fights for a party of 4, all levels, `tools/grid_budget.js`) stayed fair: 94% won, someone Down in 31%, a death in 4%, 4 rounds. Fights with a Heavy ran hot: a death in 7% and someone Down in 39%, because a Heavy's Area caught 3¼ of 4 freelancers on average against the 2½–3 the ratings assume. With Heavy fights cut to ×0.8 they matched the rest (death 2%, Down 30%), hence the **×1¼ units for Heavies on a grid** in §5. See Positioning. (The arcade's own difficulty factors are a video-game setting, not a tabletop rule: see the Arcade vs Tabletop appendix.)
- Terrain, objectives ("hold the pump for 3 rounds"), and fleeing enemies matter more than numbers. Use them.

10.8 Writing a Stat Block

> **Name** — T#, Role · **BR x · MR y** · Kind · Guard x · TN x · HP x · Speed x **Attack:** name (Defense, Single/Area, range) — Damage x, rider. **Traits:** … · **Tactics:** one sentence.

10.9 Roster

Kinds: **Pack** (MR well above BR), **Heavy** (BR close to MR), **Generalist**, **Control** (riders, Leader, Mender), **Boss**. All stat blocks use the table above; ratings are for 4 freelancers (§6 for other sizes). Stat blocks are generated from `tools/encounter_roster.py` by `tools/threat_blocks.py`; change the data there, then regenerate.

Creature	T	Role	Kind	BR	MR	Faction	Standout
Scrapjack Picker	1	Skirmisher	Pack	<1	2	Scrapjacks	Pack + Flanker
Spill Rats	1	Mook	Pack	<1	1	Spill fauna	Pack + Overwhelm: four on one freelancer pin them
Ward Tough	1	Soldier	Generalist	<1	1	Drowned Wards	Cowardly: surrenders
The Brood Matriarch	1	Boss	Boss	1	5	Spill fauna	Births Brood Spawn; Screech
Bloomhound	2	Skirmisher	Pack	<1	2	Spill fauna	Flanker + Frenzy; Held
Drain Beast	2	Brute	Heavy	2	4	Spill fauna	Engulf Tail Thrash; Bulky; Regenerating
Turret Drone	2	Artillery	Generalist	<1	2	Ostrander Remnant	Flying 10-ft Area; Explosive
Boiler Hulk	3	Brute	Heavy	3	4	Scrapjacks	Engulf Steam Vent, then skips a phase
Ostrander Cleaner	3	Soldier	Generalist	<1	3	Ostrander Remnant	Shield Wall; Purge Rifle
Sporecaller	3	Controller	Control	<1	3	Children of the Bloom	Leader + Mender; Poisoned area
Cleaner Hound	4	Skirmisher	Pack	<1	5	Ostrander Remnant	Pack + Flanker; Purge bite
Gas Bloat	4	Brute	Heavy	4	6	Children of the Bloom	30-ft Engulf; Explosive
Mirrormaw	4	Elite	Generalist	4	7	Spill fauna	Mimic; two attacks
Bloom Knight	5	Soldier	Generalist	3	5	Children of the Bloom	Armored 2; Poisoned
Damper Drone	5	Controller	Control	2	5	Ostrander Remnant	Damper Field: Unleash +1 Flux
Glasshide	5	Brute	Heavy	5	6	Spill fauna	Engulf; Territorial; Vulnerable (Shock)
Stitchwork Brood	5	Soldier	Pack	2	6	Children of the Bloom	Linked + Crowd
Warden Krell	5	Boss	Boss	5	10+	Ostrander Remnant	Calls the Line; Purge; Leader
Hunter-Killer Unit	6	Elite	Generalist	6	10	Ostrander Remnant	Hunter; two Dazing attacks
Lancer Troopers	6	Mook	Pack	1	4	Ostrander Remnant	Shield Wall + Purger
Feral Evolved	7	Elite	Generalist	7	10+	Spill fauna	Damage Gate + Shift

Creature	T	Role	Kind	BR	MR	Faction	Standout
Gutter Leviathan	7	Brute	Heavy	7	9	Spill fauna	30-ft Engulf; Bulky; Territorial
Razorwing Flock	7	Skirmisher	Pack	3	7	Spill fauna	Pack + Flanker + Frenzy
Bloom Husks	8	Mook	Pack	4	7	Children of the Bloom	Overwhelm + Crowd
Ostrander Paladin	8	Soldier	Generalist	6	8	Ostrander Remnant	Shielded; Armored 3
Seraph Gunship	8	Artillery	Heavy	8	10+	Ostrander Remnant	20-ft Engulf at 120 ft; Interference
The Drowned Choir	8	Controller	Control	8	10+	Drowned Wards	Swarm; Leader; psychic 30-ft area
Choir Thralls	9	Mook	Pack	4	8	Drowned Wards	Overwhelm + Pack
Mother of Rust	9	Controller	Control	9	10+	Scrapjacks	Leader + Mender; Exposed area
Hollow Saint	10	Skirmisher	Generalist	5	9	Children of the Bloom	Mimic + Hunter
Reactor Wraith	10	Brute	Heavy	10	10+	Spill fauna	30-ft Engulf; Interference; Bulky
The Many	10	Soldier	Pack	6	10	Children of the Bloom	Linked + Frenzy
Patient Zero	10	Boss	Boss	10	10+	Children of the Bloom	Blooms Husks; 60-ft Song; triple Shift

By party level (main uses; what a fair fight looks like at each level):

Level	Alone (BR)	Four of them (MR)
1	Brood Matriarch	Spill Rats, Ward Tough
2	Drain Beast	Scrapjack Picker, Bloomhound, Turret Drone
3	Boiler Hulk, Bloom Knight	Ostrander Cleaner, Sporecaller
4	Mirrormaw, Gas Bloat	Lancer Troopers, Drain Beast, Boiler Hulk
5	Glasshide, Warden Krell	Cleaner Hound, Bloom Knight, Damper Drone
6	Hunter-Killer Unit, Ostrander Paladin, The Many	Stitchwork Brood, Gas Bloat, Glasshide
7	Feral Evolved, Gutter Leviathan	Razorwing Flock, Bloom Husks, Mirrormaw
8	Seraph Gunship, The Drowned Choir	Ostrander Paladin, Choir Thralls
9	Mother of Rust	Hollow Saint, Gutter Leviathan
10	Reactor Wraith, Patient Zero	The Many, Hunter-Killer Unit

10.9.1 Base stage (T1–3)

10.9.1.1 Scrapjack Picker

Scrapjack Picker — T1 Skirmisher · **BR <1 · MR 2** · Pack · Guard 13 · TN 13 · HP 13 · Speed 40
Attack: *Hook-blade or Rivet Gun* (Dodge, Single, melee or 60 ft) — **6**.
Traits: Pack (+1 TN and +2 damage for each earlier Pack attack on the same target this round, max +3/+6) · **Flanker** (advantage while another Flanker is fighting).
Scavengers in welded scrap armour, magnets on their gloves. **Tactics:** Gang up on whoever has visible chrome; scatter when two are down.

10.9.1.2 Spill Rats

Spill Rats — T1 Mook · **BR <1 · MR 1** · Pack · Guard 11 · TN 13 · HP 11 · Speed 30 (climb)
Attack: *Bite* (Dodge, Single, melee) — **8**.
Traits: Pack (+1 TN and +2 damage for each earlier Pack attack on the same target this round, max +3/+6) · **Overwhelm** (the 3rd attack from its group on one freelancer in a round leaves them Prone and Held) · **Mutagenic 1**.
Hairless, glowing, wrong number of legs. **Tactics:** Pour out of pipes in fours or more; all bite the same freelancer.

10.9.1.3 Ward Tough

Ward Tough — T1 Soldier · **BR <1 · MR 1** · Generalist · Guard 12 · TN 13 · HP 32 · Speed 30
Attack: *Pipe or Pistol* (Dodge/Endure/Resist (GM picks), Single, melee or 60 ft) — **10**.
Traits: Cowardly (at half HP or less, surrenders on d6 4–6 each Enemy Phase).
Waders, a rebar club, a family to feed. **Tactics:** Wants to be paid, not killed. Surrenders at half HP.

10.9.1.4 Bloomhound

Bloomhound — T2 Skirmisher · **BR <1 · MR 2** · Pack · Guard 14 · TN 13 · HP 14 · Speed 50
Attack: *Split-Jaw* (Dodge, Single, melee) — **7**, Held.
Traits: Flanker (advantage while another Flanker is fighting) · **Frenzy** (+2 damage per ally killed this fight, max +6).
A dog that opens like a flower. **Tactics:** Hunts in packs; one holds, the rest bite. Goes wild when a packmate dies.

10.9.1.5 Drain Beast

Drain Beast — T2 Brute · **BR 2 · MR 4** · Heavy · Guard 12 · TN 13 · HP 63 · Speed 30 (swim)
Attack: *Tail Thrash* (Endure, Area, 20 ft around it) — **10**. **Engulf +3:** +3 damage to everyone caught for each freelancer caught beyond the first (max +2 freelancers). **Friendly fire:** also hits its allies in the area. Recharge 4–6 · *Crush* (Endure, Single, reach 10 ft) — **5**, Held.
Traits: Apex (while it is the only enemy standing: +2 TN, ×1½ Damage) · **Huge** · **Bulky** (before an Area attack, roll d6 per non-Mook ally; any 1–3 = it uses its single attack) · **Regenerating 3**.
A drowned bull crocodile the size of a bus. **Tactics:** Thrashes when it is surrounded; drags one victim under when it is not.

10.9.1.6 Turret Drone

Turret Drone — T2 Artillery · **BR <1 · MR 2** · Generalist · Guard 13 · TN 13 · HP 21 · Speed 30 (fly)
Attack: *Flechette Spray* (Dodge, Area, 10-ft burst, 90 ft) — **5**.
Traits: Armored 1 · **Mover (fly)** · **Explosive 6**.
A coffee-can drone with a shotgun. **Tactics:** Hovers out of reach; fires into clusters.

10.9.1.7 Boiler Hulk

Boiler Hulk — T3 Brute · **BR 3 · MR 4** · Heavy · Guard 13 · TN 14 · HP 67 · Speed 30
Attack: *Steam Vent* (Endure, Area, 20 ft around it) — **19**. **Engulf +5:** +5 damage to everyone caught for each freelancer caught beyond the first (max +2 freelancers). **Friendly fire:** also hits its allies in the area. Afterwards it skips its next Enemy Phase · *Furnace Fist* (Dodge, Single, melee) — **8**, Burning.
Traits: Armored 1 · **Apex** (while it is the only enemy standing: +2 TN, ×1½ Damage) · **Huge** ·

Bulky (before an Area attack, roll d6 per non-Mook ally; any 1–3 = it uses its single attack).
A walking furnace bolted onto a press-ganged Ward diver. **Tactics:** Wades into the middle of the party and vents. Vents again whether or not its crew is close.

10.9.1.8 Ostrander Cleaner

Ostrander Cleaner — T3 Soldier · **BR <1 · MR 3** · Generalist · Guard 14 · TN 14 · HP 24 · Speed 30
Attack: *Purge Rifle* (Dodge, Single, 120 ft) — **10**, loses one Primed Surge · *Foam Sprayer* (Endure, Area, 15-ft cone) — **8**.
Traits: Armored 1 · **Shield Wall** (+1 Guard per other Shield Wall ally fighting, max +2).
Hazmat suit, antimutagen rifle, no face. **Tactics:** Advances in pairs behind riot shields; foams anyone mid-Surge.

10.9.1.9 Sporecaller

Sporecaller — T3 Controller · **BR <1 · MR 3** · Control · Guard 14 · TN 14 · HP 19 · Speed 30
Attack: *Spore Hymn* (Endure, Area, 20-ft burst, 60 ft) — **4**, Poisoned.
Traits: Leader (other enemies deal +3 damage) · **Mender** (instead of attacking, heals the most-hurt non-Mook ally below 60% HP for 10) · **Mutagenic 1**.
A Bloom priest with a mouth full of flowers. **Tactics:** Stays behind its flock, sings, and knits their wounds shut.

10.9.2 Evolution I stage (T4–6)

10.9.2.1 Cleaner Hound

Cleaner Hound — T4 Skirmisher · **BR <1 · MR 5** · Pack · Guard 15 · TN 16 · HP 33 · Speed 50
Attack: *Injector Bite* (Dodge, Single, melee) — **18**, loses one Primed Surge.
Traits: Pack (+1 TN and +5 damage for each earlier Pack attack on the same target this round, max +3/+15) · **Flanker** (advantage while another Flanker is fighting).
Ostrander's chrome dogs. **Tactics:** Run in threes or fours, chase whoever just Surged, and drain their Primed Surges.

10.9.2.2 Gas Bloat

Gas Bloat — T4 Brute · **BR 4 · MR 6** · Heavy · Guard 13 · TN 16 · HP 105 · Speed 20
Attack: *Spore Gout* (Endure, Area, 30 ft around it) — **15**, Poisoned. **Engulf +6:** +6 damage to everyone caught for each freelancer caught beyond the first (max +2 freelancers). **Friendly fire:** also hits its allies in the area. Recharge 5–6 · *Slam* (Dodge, Single, melee) — **9**.
Traits: Apex (while it is the only enemy standing: +2 TN, ×1½ Damage) · **Explosive 15** · **Bulky** (before an Area attack, roll d6 per non-Mook ally; any 1–3 = it uses its single attack).
A Bloom convert swollen into a weather balloon of spores. **Tactics:** Drifts into the biggest crowd it can find and bursts.

10.9.2.3 Mirrormaw

Mirrormaw — T4 Elite · **BR 4 · MR 7** · Generalist · Guard 14 · TN 16 · HP 155 · Speed 30 (climb)
Attack ×2: *Glass Teeth* (Dodge, Single, melee) — **31**, Exposed.
Traits: Mimic.
Looks like a vending machine, a door, or your friend. **Tactics:** Waits. Bites the one who touches it.

10.9.2.4 Bloom Knight

Bloom Knight — T5 Soldier · **BR 3 · MR 5** · Generalist · Guard 15 · TN 17 · HP 70 · Speed 30
Attack: *Thorn Glaive* (Dodge, Single, reach 10 ft) — **27**, Poisoned.
Traits: Armored 2 · **Mutagenic 1**.
Holy warrior grown from a single rosebush. **Tactics:** Stands in front of Sporecallers and never retreats.

10.9.2.5 Damper Drone

Damper Drone — T5 Controller · **BR 2 · MR 5** · Control · Guard 15 · TN 17 · HP 62 · Speed 30 (fly)
Attack: *Null Pulse* (Resist, Area, 10-ft burst, 60 ft) — **12**, Dazed.
Traits: Armored 1 · **Damper Field** (while it lives, every Unleash costs +1 Flux) · **Mover (fly)**.
A floating antimutagen censer. **Tactics:** Hangs back over the Ostrander line; its field makes every Surge cost more.

10.9.2.6 Glasshide

Glasshide — T5 Brute · **BR 5 · MR 6** · Heavy · Guard 14 · TN 17 · HP 123 · Speed 30
Attack: *Shatter Roar* (Endure, Area, 20 ft around it) — **29**. **Engulf +10:** +10 damage to everyone caught for each freelancer caught beyond the first (max +2 freelancers). **Friendly fire:** also hits its allies in the area. Recharge 4–6 · *Crystal Maul* (Endure, Single, reach 10 ft) — **14**, Prone.
Traits: Armored 2 · **Apex** (while it is the only enemy standing: +2 TN, ×1½ Damage) · **Huge** · **Territorial** (while a rival of its kind lives, d6 1–4: it attacks the rival instead) · **Bulky** (before an Area attack, roll d6 per non-Mook ally; any 1–3 = it uses its single attack) · **Vulnerable (Shock)**.
A bear grown into a cathedral of quartz. **Tactics:** Charges the loudest thing. Fights any other Glasshide on sight.

10.9.2.7 Stitchwork Brood

Stitchwork Brood — T5 Soldier · **BR 2 · MR 6** · Pack · Guard 15 · TN 17 · HP 66 · Speed 30
Attack: *Sutured Claws* (Dodge/Endure/Resist (GM picks), Single, melee) — **26**.
Traits: Linked (damage to one is split evenly among all Linked creatures) · **Crowd** (+3 damage per other enemy fighting, max +9).
Bloom converts sewn into one nervous system with living thread. **Tactics:** Move as one; a wound on one bleeds on all of them.

10.9.2.8 Hunter-Killer Unit

Hunter-Killer Unit — T6 Elite · **BR 6 · MR 10** · Generalist · Guard 16 · TN 18 · HP 195 · Speed 40
Attack ×2: *Mono-wire or Arc Pistol* (Dodge, Single, reach 10 ft or 60 ft) — **38**, Dazed.
Traits: Armored 2 · **Hunter** (half its attacks go to the lowest-HP freelancer).
Ostrander's chrome assassin. **Tactics:** Kills the medic first.

10.9.2.9 Lancer Troopers

Lancer Troopers — T6 Mook · **BR 1 · MR 4** · Pack · Guard 15 · TN 18 · HP 31 · Speed 30
Attack: *Shock Lance* (Dodge, Single, 30 ft) — **23**, Dazed.
Traits: Shield Wall (+1 Guard per other Shield Wall ally fighting, max +3) · **Purger**.
Ostrander riot line. **Tactics:** Locked shields in sixes. Two hold the door; the rest lance the Chrome.

10.9.3 Evolution II stage (T7–10)

10.9.3.1 Feral Evolved

Feral Evolved — T7 Elite · **BR 7 · MR 10+** · Generalist · Guard 17 · TN 20 · HP 300 · Speed 40
Attack ×2: *Wrong Claws* (Dodge, Single, melee) — **46**.
Traits: Regenerating 8 · **Mutagenic 2** · **Damage Gate** (the first time it would drop below half HP it stops at half and Shifts).
Shift (half HP): +2 Guard; +9 Damage; everyone within 30 ft is Shaken (Resist vs TN).
A freelancer whose second Evolution went wrong. **Tactics:** It remembers your names.

10.9.3.2 Gutter Leviathan

Gutter Leviathan — T7 Brute · **BR 7 · MR 9** · Heavy · Guard 16 · TN 20 · HP 270 · Speed 20 (swim 40)
Attack: *Undertow* (Endure, Area, 30 ft around it) — **30**, Prone. **Engulf +10:** +10 damage to everyone caught for each freelancer caught beyond the first (max +2 freelancers). **Friendly fire:** also hits its allies in the area. Recharge 4–6 · *Swallow* (Endure, Single, reach 15 ft) — **15**, Held.
Traits: Armored 3 · **Apex** (while it is the only enemy standing: +2 TN, ×1½ Damage) · **Huge** · **Bulky** (before an Area attack, roll d6 per non-Mook ally; any 1–3 = it uses its single attack) · **Territorial** (while a rival of its kind lives, d6 1–4: it attacks the rival instead).
The thing that lives in the flooded subway. **Tactics:** Surfaces, drowns everyone near the water, dives. Two never share a tunnel.

10.9.3.3 Razorwing Flock

Razorwing Flock — T7 Skirmisher · **BR 3 · MR 7** · Pack · Guard 18 · TN 20 · HP 55 · Speed 60 (fly)
Attack: *Razor Dive* (Dodge, Single, melee) — **23**.
Traits: Flanker (advantage while another Flanker is fighting) · **Frenzy** (+9 damage per ally killed this fight, max +27) · **Pack** (+1 TN and +9 damage for each earlier Pack attack on the same target this round, max +3/+27).
Pigeons the Spill turned into flying knives. **Tactics:** Dive one target from every side; scream and dive harder when one falls.

10.9.3.4 Bloom Husks

Bloom Husks — T8 Mook · **BR 4 · MR 7** · Pack · Guard 17 · TN 21 · HP 62 · Speed 30
Attack: *Root Grip* (Endure, Single, melee) — **37**, Held.
Traits: Overwhelm (the 3rd attack from its group on one freelancer in a round leaves them Prone and Held) · **Crowd** (+4 damage per other enemy fighting, max +13).
Bodies the Bloom finished with, still walking. **Tactics:** Shamble in crowds; three on one freelancer drag them down.

10.9.3.5 Ostrander Paladin

Ostrander Paladin — T8 Soldier · **BR 6 · MR 8** · Generalist · Guard 18 · TN 21 · HP 140 · Speed 30
Attack: *Lance Cannon* (Dodge/Endure/Resist (GM picks), Single, 90 ft) — **42**.
Traits: Armored 3 · **Shielded**.
A powered exo-frame with a saint painted on the chest. **Tactics:** Walks through gunfire to plant its lance; never breaks formation.

10.9.3.6 Seraph Gunship

Seraph Gunship — T8 Artillery · **BR 8 · MR 10+** · Heavy · Guard 18 · TN 21 · HP 170 · Speed 40 (fly)
Attack: *Rotary Cannon* (Dodge, Area, 20-ft burst, 120 ft) — **51**. **Engulf +26:** +26 damage to everyone caught for each freelancer caught beyond the first (max +2 freelancers). Recharge 4–6 · *Door Gun* (Dodge, Single, 120 ft) — **20**.
Traits: Armored 3 · **Apex** (while it is the only enemy standing: +2 TN, ×1½ Damage) · **Mover (fly)** · **Interference** (only one Interference creature can use an Area attack per Enemy Phase) · **Explosive 24**.
An Ostrander drone with angel wings painted on. **Tactics:** Circles the rooftops and shreds anyone in the open. Gunships share one fire-control net.

10.9.3.7 The Drowned Choir

The Drowned Choir — T8 Controller · **BR 8 · MR 10+** · Control · Guard 18 · TN 21 · HP 365 · Speed 20 (swim)
Attack: *Undertow Song* (Resist, Area, 30 ft around it) — **36**, Shaken (psychic: ignores Armor).
Traits: Swarm · **Mutagenic 2** · **Leader** (other enemies deal +9 damage).
Fifty drowned voices fused into one. **Tactics:** Sings the living toward the water; its thralls sing louder near it.

10.9.3.8 Choir Thralls

Choir Thralls — T9 Mook · **BR 4 · MR 8** · Pack · Guard 18 · TN 22 · HP 63 · Speed 30
Attack: *Grasping Hands* (Endure, Single, melee) — **38**, Held.
Traits: Overwhelm (the 3rd attack from its group on one freelancer in a round leaves them Prone and Held) · **Pack** (+1 TN and +10 damage for each earlier Pack attack on the same target this round, max +3/+30) · **Mutagenic 1**.
The Choir's converts, still singing. **Tactics:** Come in sixes to pin you down for something worse.

10.9.3.9 Mother of Rust

Mother of Rust — T9 Controller · **BR 9 · MR 10+** · Control · Guard 19 · TN 22 · HP 486 · Speed 30 (climb)
Attack: *Corrosion Tide* (Endure, Area, 20 ft around her) — **55**, Exposed.
Traits: Leader (other enemies deal +10 damage) · **Mender** (instead of attacking, heals the most-hurt non-Mook ally below 60% HP for 40).
The Scrapjacks' queen, a cathedral of rust and stolen limbs. **Tactics:** Melts Armor, rebuilds her crew from scrap, and lets them feast.

10.9.3.10 Hollow Saint

Hollow Saint — T10 Skirmisher · **BR 5 · MR 9** · Generalist · Guard 21 · TN 23 · HP 95 · Speed 50 (fly)
Attack: *Halo Edge or Whisper* (Dodge/Endure/Resist (GM picks), Single, melee or 60 ft) — **38**, Shaken.
Traits: Mimic · **Hunter** (half its attacks go to the lowest-HP freelancer).
A Bloom martyr that came back beautiful. **Tactics:** Appears among the wounded and offers to end the pain.

10.9.3.11 Reactor Wraith

Reactor Wraith — T10 Brute · **BR 10 · MR 10+** · Heavy · Guard 19 · TN 23 · HP 271 · Speed 30 (fly)
Attack: *Meltdown* (Endure, Area, 30 ft around it) — **48**. **Engulf +16:** +16 damage to everyone caught for each freelancer caught beyond the first (max +2 freelancers). **Friendly fire:** also hits its allies in the area. Afterwards it skips its next Enemy Phase · *Irradiate* (Endure, Single, 30 ft) — **24**, Burning.
Traits: Armored 2 · **Apex** (while it is the only enemy standing: +2 TN, ×1½ Damage) · **Huge** · **Interference** (only one Interference creature can use an Area attack per Enemy Phase) · **Bulky** (before an Area attack, roll d6 per non-Mook ally; any 1–3 = it uses its single attack).
The ghost of a cooling tower. **Tactics:** Hovers into the middle of the fight and goes critical. Wraiths drain each other.

10.9.3.12 The Many

The Many — T10 Soldier · **BR 6 · MR 10** · Pack · Guard 20 · TN 23 · HP 142 · Speed 30
Attack: *Thousand Hands* (Dodge/Endure/Resist (GM picks), Single, melee) — **42**.
Traits: Linked (damage to one is split evenly among all Linked creatures) · **Frenzy** (+10 damage per ally killed this fight, max +30).
Patient Zero's first congregation, grown together at the roots. **Tactics:** Surround; when one falls the rest scream in one voice and push harder.

10.9.4 Bosses

10.9.4.1 The Brood Matriarch

The Brood Matriarch — T1 Boss · **BR 1 · MR 5** · Boss · Guard 13 · TN 13 · HP 58 · Speed 0 (rooted); 30 after Shift
Actions (one per Enemy Phase + one Interrupt): *Brood-Lash* (Dodge, Single, reach 15 ft) — **6**, Held · *Screech* (Resist, Area, 30 ft around her) — **4**, Shaken. Recharge 5–6 · *Birth:* 2 Brood Spawn join the fight (max 4), Recharge 5–6 — each: Guard 11 · TN 13 · HP 4 · Bite (Dodge) 3.
Traits: Huge · **Mutagenic 1**.
Shift (half HP): ends every condition on itself; *Brood-Lash* (Dodge, Single, reach 15 ft) — **5** to each of 2 targets, Held.
A womb the size of a truck, rooted into the pipes. **Tactics:** Holds the strongest freelancer, Births when she has fewer than 3 rats, Screeches when 2+ freelancers are near.

10.9.4.2 Warden Krell

Warden Krell — T5 Boss · **BR 5 · MR 10+** · Boss · Guard 16 · TN 17 · HP 234 · Speed 30
Actions (one per Enemy Phase + one Interrupt): *Purge Carbine* (Dodge, Single, 120 ft) — **14**, loses one Primed Surge · *Riot Slam* (Endure, Area, 15-ft cone) — **11**, Prone. Recharge 5–6 · *Call the Line:* 2 Riot Line Troopers join the fight (max 4), Recharge 6 — each: Guard 15 · TN 18 · HP 15 · Shock Lance (Dodge) 7, Dazed.
Traits: Armored 2 · **Leader** (other enemies deal +6 damage).
Shift (half HP): +1 Armor; ends every condition on itself; *Riot Slam* (Endure, Area, 20 ft around him) — **11**, Prone. Recharge 5–6.
The Ostrander officer who ran the Lockdown camps. **Tactics:** Opens from cover, Purges whoever has the most Primed Surges, and calls the Line the moment the party bunches up.

10.9.4.3 Patient Zero

Patient Zero — T10 Boss · **BR 10 · MR 10+** · Boss · Guard 21 · TN 23 · HP 282 · Speed 40 (fly after Shift)
Actions (one per Enemy Phase + one Interrupt): *Unmaking Touch* (Endure, Single, reach 15 ft) — **25**, +2 Flux · *The First Song* (Resist, Area, 60 ft around it) — **15**, Shaken (psychic: ignores Armor). Recharge 5–6 · *Bloom:* 2 Husks join the fight (max 4), Recharge 5–6 — each: Guard 17 · TN 21 · HP 16 · Root Grip (Endure) 11, Held.
Traits: Huge · **Regenerating 8**.
Shift (half HP): +1 Guard; +1 Interrupt; *Unmaking Touch* (Endure, Single, reach 15 ft) — **20** to each of 3 targets, +2 Flux.
The first person ever to take the Mutagen, still alive in the reactor core. **Tactics:** Talks before it fights. Its Shift should land after the party has spent their Final Forms.

10.10 Quick Reskins (d6)

Need a monster now? Pick a stat block above and roll a new look.

d6	Bio twist	Chrome twist
1	Fused from several animals	Built from a dead vehicle
2	Coated in fungus or moss	Runs on stolen Mutagen batteries
3	Too many eyes	One huge lens
4	Translucent; organs visible	Wrapped in Ostrander warning tape
5	Sings or hums	Plays old advertising jingles
6	Was clearly once a person	Is clearly still a person inside

11. Starter Mission — *Pumpstation 9*

A one-session mission for **3–5 level 1 freelancers**. Five pregenerated characters (one per Base Form) are at the end. Numbers assume 4 players; each fight lists what to change for 3 or 5 (checked in `tools/sim_results/11_starter_mission.md`).

11.1 The Brief

Handler Dez Okafor, GRAFT Field Office 3, over a crackling radio:

> "Pumpstation 9 keeps the Fenwick Ward from flooding. Since Tuesday it's been pumping **Mutagen** into their water instead of out. Ward council's paying us; we're paying you. **300 Scrip each** to shut the intake and kill whatever's in there. Bring back anything weird. Don't drink anything."

What's really going on: A Scrapjack crew, paid by an Ostrander Remnant agent, planted a Brood Matriarch egg in the intake to test whether a mutagenic bloom can be weaponized through a water supply. The Matriarch has rooted into the pipes. The Scrapjacks are still here, stripping the pump room and waiting for their pickup.

Spill Clock: 6 segments. Tick it for loud noises, long rests, failed stealth, and Overloads. When it fills, see *Out*.

11.2 Scene 1: The Fenwick Toll

The only dry road to the pumpstation crosses a Ward barricade. **Three Ward Toughs** (T1 Soldiers, MR 1) want a 50-Scrip "toll" each.

- **Talk:** Chutzpah DC 13 lets the party through free; with a good argument (*"we're here to fix your water"*) roll with advantage.
- **Fight (Standard, 3 units):** 3 Ward Toughs (MR 1 → 1 unit each). For 3 players use 2; for 5 use 4. They're Cowardly (they surrender at half HP), and the Ward council will dock the party's pay by 100.
- **Sneak:** A group Moxie check DC 13 through the flooded alleys. Failure ticks the clock and they arrive soaked (each takes 2 damage from the cold).
- **Clue:** Any Tough knows "some chrome-heads went in Monday with a crate."

11.3 Scene 2: The Pump Hall

A three-storey hall of rusting turbines, waist-deep green water on the lower floor, catwalks above. **A Scrapjack Picker** is prying copper from the turbines while **two Spill Rats** nest in the pipes. More Pickers are asleep upstairs (a second one joins if the Spill Clock ticks during the fight).

- **Fight (Standard, 3 units):** 1 Picker (MR 2 → 1½) + 2 Spill Rats (MR 1 → 1 each). For 3 players: 1 Picker + 1 Rat. For 5: the same fight (Packs focus one target, so a bigger party doesn't make Downs much rarer: 26% with 5 players vs 27% with 4); add a third Rat only for a Hard fight. The Rats attack anyone in the water first, all on the same freelancer (Pack, Overwhelm). *v0.2's 2 Pickers + 4 Rats is a Deadly 7 units under the new table: an 82% chance someone goes Down.*

- **Terrain:** Water is difficult terrain. Catwalks give partial cover. A turbine can be restarted (Gumption DC 13, Action): everyone in the water takes 7 Shock (**Area**, Endure for half).
- **Twist:** A Picker carries an Ostrander-coded **data chit** and a radio: their pickup is "in one hour." Reading the chit (Gumption DC 16 or a Hack deck) reveals the plan.
- If a Picker is captured: Chutzpah DC 13 to make them talk. They know the egg went "into the big intake pipe."

Breather: The control room is defensible. The party can take a Breather here (tick the clock twice).

11.4 Scene 3: The Intake

A flooded concrete cathedral where the river pipe meets the pumps. Glowing roots of flesh cover the walls. In the middle, fused to the intake grate, is the **Brood Matriarch** with **two Spill Rats** already crawling on her.

- **Fight (Hard):** the Matriarch alone (BR 1, a whole Hard budget); she Births her own Brood Spawn. **Scale her for the party** (Threats §6): HP and all Damage ×¾ for 3 players (HP 43), ×1¼ for 5 (HP 72). The two Spill Rats on her flee into the pipes when the fight starts. See Threats.
- **The Valve:** A huge manual valve stands 20 ft from the Matriarch. **Three successful Grit or Gumption checks (DC 13, Action each)** close it. When it closes, she shrieks, is **Dazed** until the end of the next Enemy Phase, and can't Birth for the rest of the fight. Closing the valve also completes the mission objective, even if she survives.
- **The Sample:** Harvest with Gumption DC 12 after she dies: *Brood Web* (Burst + Snare).

11.5 Out

- If the clock filled at any point, **two Ostrander Cleaners** (T3 Soldiers, MR 3 → 2 units each: Standard-to-Hard at level 1 by the sims, Deadly for a tired party) arrive by boat as the party leaves. Running is the smart choice: a group Moxie check DC 13 to reach the alleys. On failure, the Cleaners get one Enemy Phase of shots before the party escapes.
- If the clock never filled, the pickup boat arrives empty; the party can ambush it and capture the Ostrander agent, **Mr. Hale**, a calm man with no mutations and an expensive umbrella.

11.6 Debrief

- Pay: 300 Scrip each; +100 each for the data chit or Mr. Hale; −100 total if they fought the Ward.
- GRAFT asks for the Sample. Players who hand it over get +50 each. Players who keep it can splice it.
- Everyone reaches **level 2.**
- **Hook:** the data chit lists five more pumpstations.

11.7 Pregenerated Freelancers (Level 1)

One per Base Form. All have Rank 1, Prime 2, Sequence d4 (slot 4 is Wild), Juice 1, Light armor, a Damper, and the kit items listed. Each has **6 nodes**: 3 in the primary tree, 2 in the secondary and 1 in the tertiary.

11.7.1 Vex — Skitter (Bio)

Spill-Born courier with mantis claws, wired nerves and the reflexes of a cockroach.

- **Stats:** Moxie +3, Gumption +2, Grit +1, Nerve +0, Chutzpah −1
- **HP** 14 · **Armor** 1 · **Speed** 50 · **Flux Limit** 5
- **Defenses:** Dodge +4, Endure +2, Resist +1
- **Knacks:** Scavenging, Parkour, Gang Turf
- **Augments:** Wiring: *Quickened*, *Capacitor*, *Slipstream* · Limbs: *Natural Weapons*, *Spring Legs* · Senses: *Keen* (all Bio)
- **Attacks:** Claws +4, 1d8+3 (+1d8 Shock once per turn, Capacitor) · Pistol +1, 1d6 (60 ft, suppressed)
- **Surges:** 1 *Mantis Lunge* (Strike + Kinetic: +4, 3d10+3, push 10 ft) · 2 *Live Wire* (Bolt + Shock, Moxie: +4, 2d8+3 Shock, Dazed) · 3 *Slip Veil* (Infuse + Veil: target Veiled) · 4 Wild
- **Gear:** Sneak kit (two Light melee, Pistol with Suppressor, Breach kit)
- **Perk:** Advantage on Endure vs poison, disease, and Flux-adding attacks. Dash as a Quick action; never provokes Opportunity Strikes. **Bio:** Knit 3 HP (3 Bio trees × Rank 1), Bloom table.

11.7.2 Juno — Oracle (Chrome)

Corporate washout with a sniper's optic and an encrypted voice in everyone's ear.

- **Stats:** Nerve +3, Chutzpah +2, Moxie +1, Gumption +0, Grit −1
- **HP** 10 · **Armor** 1 · **Speed** 40 · **Flux Limit** 8
- **Defenses:** Dodge +2, Endure +0, Resist +4
- **Knacks:** Corporate Protocol, Ostrander Security, Fast Talk
- **Augments:** Senses: *Keen*, *Target Lock*, *Threat Sense* · Mind: *Uplink*, *Iron Will* · Wiring: *Quickened* (all Chrome)
- **Attacks:** Rifle +4, 1d8+3 (120 ft; +1d8 vs her Target Lock) · Mind Spike +4, 1d8+3 Psychic (60 ft)
- **Surges:** 1 *Neural Spike* (Bolt + Dread: +4, 2d8+3 Psychic, Shaken) · 2 *Dazzle* (Bolt + Glare: +4, 2d8+3 Blaze, Blinded) · 3 *Hive Whisper* (Infuse + Link: target and 1 more ally get advantage on their next roll) · 4 Wild
- **Gear:** Gunhand kit (Rifle, Pistol, Frag grenade), +100 Scrip
- **Perk:** One old contact per mission. Her group can't be surprised. **Chrome:** Firmware swap, Glitch table, disadvantage vs Shock, Upkeep 75 per mission (GRAFT prepays 25).

11.7.3 Ozzie — Alembic (Splice)

A clinic rat with acid glands in his throat and a plated chest his surgeon is still paying off.

- **Stats:** Gumption +3, Grit +2, Nerve +1, Moxie +0, Chutzpah −1
- **HP** 18 · **Armor** 2 · **Speed** 30 · **Flux Limit** 5 (Splice)
- **Defenses:** Dodge +1, Endure +3, Resist +2
- **Knacks:** Street Medicine, Chemistry, Black-Market Contacts
- **Augments:** Glands: *Spit*, *Stim Gland*, *Antibodies* (Bio) · Hide: *Plating*, *Thick* (Chrome) · Mind: *Uplink* (Bio)
- **Attacks:** Spit +4 (Gumption), 1d8+3 Toxin/Corrode (30 ft) · Mind Spike +2, 1d8+1 Psychic · Pistol +2, 1d6+1

- **Surges:** 1 *Field Dressing* (Infuse + Mend: 2d8+3 HP) · 2 *Acid Bloom* (Burst + Corrode, Gumption: +4, 2d6, Exposed) · 3 *Stomp* (Pulse + Quake: +3, 2d6, Prone) · 4 Wild
- **Gear:** Medic kit (Pistol, Standard melee, 2 Medkits, 2 Stims)
- **Perk:** Patch heals +1 extra; Scars and Faults cost him half to remove. Stim Gland twice per Breather; can't be Poisoned. **Splice:** Knit 2, roll both Overload tables and choose, Upkeep 25 (prepaid).

11.7.4 Rook — Juggernaut (Chrome)

Ward militia veteran with piston fists, a riveted hide and a voice like a closing door.

- **Stats:** Grit +3, Nerve +2, Chutzpah +1, Moxie +0, Gumption −1
- **HP** 20 · **Armor** 2 · **Speed** 30 · **Flux Limit** 7
- **Defenses:** Dodge +1, Endure +4, Resist +3
- **Knacks:** Squad Tactics, Intimidation, Demolition
- **Augments:** Hide: *Plating*, *Thick*, *Barbs* · Limbs: *Natural Weapons*, *Extra Arm* · Glands: *Spit* (all Chrome)
- **Attacks:** Sledge +4, 1d10+3 · Piston Fists +4, 1d8+3 (+1 die once per turn, Extra Arm) · Spit +3 (Nerve), 1d8+2
- **Surges:** 1 *Piston Slam* (Strike + Kinetic: +4, 3d10+3, push 10 ft) · 2 *Floor Breaker* (Pulse + Quake: +4, 2d6, Prone) · 3 *Bulkhead* (Infuse + Shell: 2d6+3 temp HP, +1 Armor) · 4 Wild
- **Gear:** Bruiser kit (Heavy melee, Medkit, Grapnel)
- **Perk:** +2 to his roll in group initiative; Brace as a Quick action once per combat. Melee attackers that damage him take 2. **Chrome:** Firmware, Glitch table, disadvantage vs Shock, Upkeep 75 (GRAFT prepays 25).

11.7.5 Mags — Siren (Bio)

A Bloom street-preacher with a voice that harmonises with itself and a crowd that follows her home.

- **Stats:** Chutzpah +3, Moxie +2, Gumption +1, Grit +0, Nerve −1
- **HP** 12 · **Armor** 1 · **Speed** 40 · **Flux Limit** 4
- **Defenses:** Dodge +3, Endure +1, Resist +0 (advantage: Iron Will)
- **Knacks:** Bloom Lore, Street Preaching, Gambling
- **Augments:** Mind: *Uplink*, *Iron Will*, *Commanding Voice* · Wiring: *Quickened*, *Slipstream* · Limbs: *Natural Weapons* (all Bio)
- **Attacks:** Mind Spike +4 (Chutzpah), 1d8+3 Psychic (60 ft) · Claws +3 (Moxie), 1d8+2
- **Surges:** 1 *Nightmare* (Bolt + Dread, Chutzpah: +4, 2d8+3 Psychic, Shaken) · 2 *Hold Them* (Wave + Snare, Moxie: +3, 2d6, Held) · 3 *Go, Go!* (Infuse + Haste: an ally takes a Move and an Action) · 4 Wild
- **Gear:** Face kit (Concealed Pistol, Light melee, Hack deck, Flashbang, +50 Scrip)
- **Perk:** Once per Lockdown, reroll an Overload result and choose. Rally as a Quick action. Can't be Shaken. **Bio:** Knit 3, Bloom table. *Her Limit is only 4: she will Overload. That's the point of her.*

Part Three: Guides and Reference

The one-page summary, a step-by-step building guide, how the web arcade differs from these rules, and the glossary.

12. Quick Reference

12.1 The Roll

d20 + Stat (+ Rank) ≥ target. Rank always on attacks and defenses; on checks only with a Knack. Ties: player wins.
Rank = level ÷ 2, round up (1–5). **Adv/Dis:** 2d20 keep high/low. Nat 20 attack = Crit (double dice). Nat 20 defense = no damage + attacker Exposed. Nat 1 = fail.

DC	10 Easy	13 Standard	16 Hard	19 Extreme	22 Mutant	25 Monstrous	28 Mythic

12.2 Base Forms

Form	+3	+2	+1	+0/−1	Trees (prim / sec / tert)	Evo I (L4)	Evo II (L7)
Juggernaut	Grit	Nerve	Chutzpah	Moxie, Gumption	Hide / Limbs / Glands	Siege Hide	Fortress
Skitter	Moxie	Gumption	Grit	Nerve, Chutzpah	Wiring / Limbs / Senses	Mantis Reflex	Lightning Step
Oracle	Nerve	Chutzpah	Moxie	Grit, Gumption	Senses / Mind / Wiring	Foresight	Thousand Eyes
Alembic	Gumption	Grit	Nerve	Moxie, Chutzpah	Glands / Hide / Mind	Transmute	Panacea
Siren	Chutzpah	Moxie	Gumption	Grit, Nerve	Mind / Wiring / Limbs	Siren Song	Crown of Will

Stages: Base +3/+2/+1/+0/−1 → **Evo I (L4)** +5/+3/+2/+1/+0 → **Evo II (L7)** +8/+4/+3/+2/+1 → Final Form (L10, active) primary +10. **Each Evolution:** stats, +1 Prime, die jump (d6→d8→d12), +1 Signature Surge, Evolution node, new look; **Emerge** in the next first fight (temp HP 2×level, enemies within 30 ft Shaken, first Signature free).
Nodes: L1 = 3 primary + 2 secondary + 1 tertiary. Each level: +1 primary (auto) + 1 secondary *or* tertiary. Tier II: L4+ & 3 nodes in tree. Apex: L7+ & 6 other nodes, primary/secondary only. Primary full at L8 → overflow.

12.3 Stats

Grit smash/endure/HP · **Moxie** dodge/sneak/finesse · **Nerve** aim/notice/resist/Limit · **Gumption** fix/hack/heal/know · **Chutzpah** talk/lie/taunt/rally/Dread
Defenses: Dodge = Moxie+Rank · Endure = Grit+Rank · Resist = Nerve+Rank

12.4 Derived

HP 12 + 2×Grit, +5/level · Flux Limit 4 + Rank + Nerve (Splice −1) · Speed 30 ft (6 squares) · Armor max 4 (Unbreakable 5, Siege Hide 6) · Juice start 1, max 3

12.5 Round

Player Phase (any order) → **Enemy Phase** (enemies one at a time in one sweep; players defend).
Turn: Move + Action + Quick; 1 Reaction per round.
Actions: Attack · Unleash · Dash · Brace · Help · Patch · Analyze · Taunt · Rally · Grapple/Shove · Other
Quick: draw, stim, Churn, Target Lock, talk
Reactions: Opportunity Strike when an enemy leaves your reach (melee weapon attack); each enemy gets one per round on you if you leave its reach (move carefully, at half speed, to avoid it). Dazed: no Reactions.
Ranges: Help 30 ft · Analyze/Taunt/Rally 60 ft · Patch touch · ranged weapons to 2× range at disadvantage (not Areas/grenades/Surges) · shooting with an enemy adjacent = disadvantage (an enemy shooter with a freelancer adjacent: you defend with advantage).
Positioning: theatre of the mind (Close 5 ft · Near 30 ft · Far 120 ft · Distant) or grid (1 square = 5 ft, diagonals = 1; 30 ft = 6 squares; 10-ft burst = 5×5 squares; 15-ft cone 3 deep; line 1 wide; walls block sight and Areas).
Wait: go later in the Player Phase if you haven't acted. **Boss Interrupt:** one action (no Move) after any player's turn, once per round.
Damage: Rank × weapon die + stat. Armor −X per hit (min 1). Area: miss/successful defense = half.

12.6 Surges

Prime at combat start: roll Sequence die × Prime (2; 3 from L4; 4 from L7). Doubles = **Amped** (0 Flux). Wild slot = roll Wild table (each separately, never doubles).
Unleash (Action): pay 1 Flux + 1 per Twist; a missed Strike/Bolt stays Primed. **Churn** (Quick): +1 Flux, roll once more; not on a turn you Unleash (max Prime + 1 held).
Signature Surges (1 from L4, 2 from L7): always Primed, once per round each, normal Flux, not on the Sequence.
Surge stat: the Shape's stat or the stat of the Effect's tree (Hide Grit · Limbs Grit/Moxie · Senses Nerve · Glands Gumption · Wiring Moxie · Mind Chutzpah).
Juice: reroll a d20 · choose a Prime · end a condition.

Shape	Target	Stat	Dice
Strike	melee	Grit/Moxie	(Rank+1)d10 + stat
Bolt	60 ft	Nerve	(Rank+1)d8 + stat
Burst*	10 ft r. @60 ft	Nerve	(Rank+1)d6
Wave*	15 cone/30 line	Grit/Nerve	(Rank+1)d6
Pulse*	10 ft around you	Grit	(Rank+1)d6
Infuse	self/ally 30 ft	—	effect

**Area: one roll vs each Guard; miss = half, no rider.*

Effects: Kinetic (+1 die, push 10) · Blaze (Burning) · Shock (Dazed) · Toxin (Poisoned) · Corrode (Exposed) · Snare (Held) · Quake (Prone) · Glare (Blinded) · Dread (Shaken)
Infuse: Mend ((Rank+1)d8+Gumption) · Shell ((Rank+1)d6+Grit temp HP, +1 Armor) · Haste (ally: Move + Action) · Veil (adv. on defenses + next attack) · Link (adv. for target + Rank allies)
Twists (+1 Flux): Chain · Linger · Leech · Overcharge (+2 dice) · Sure (advantage) · Reach (×2) · Hush

Level	1	2–3	4–6	7–10
Sequence	d4	d6	d8	d12
Prime	2	2	3	4
Signatures	—	—	1	2

12.7 Flux & Overload

Gain Flux: Unleash, Churn, Push. Over Limit → **Overload:** take Rank d6 (min 1 HP left), roll d12 Bloom (Bio) / Glitch (Chrome) / both, pick (Splice), Flux → 0. Breather/Lockdown → Flux 0. **Last Gasp:** once per Lockdown, at 0 HP Overload instead and stay at 1 HP.

12.8 Conditions (until end of affected creature's next turn)

Blinded dis. on attacks, attackers adv. · **Burning** 2×source Rank dmg at the start of its next turn, then out · **Dazed** no Quick/Reaction/Specials; Boss 1 action · **Exposed** −2 Guard / −2 defense · **Held** speed 0 · **Poisoned** half damage dealt · **Prone** melee adv./ranged dis. against; stand = ½ speed · **Shaken** dis. on attacks & checks, can't approach source · **Veiled** adv. on defense & next attack
Enemy advantage = player rolls defense with disadvantage.

12.9 Down

0 HP: Prone, crawl 5 ft. End of each Enemy Phase: Endure DC 10, fail = Death mark (nat 20: up at 1 HP). Damage while Down = mark (2 on a failed defense vs a Boss). 3 marks = dead. Any healing = up. Roll Injury (d6). Everyone Down = the fight is lost. Bosses end one condition at the start of their turn.

12.10 Rest

Breather (1 hr, 2 per Lockdown): regain ½ Max HP (+Knit, which also triggers after each combat), Flux 0, clear Death marks. **Lockdown** (8 hr safe): full reset.

12.11 Threat Builder & Encounters

T	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
Guard	12	13	14	14	15	16	17	18	19	20
TN	13	13	14	16	17	18	20	21	22	23
HP	28	30	38	62	74	78	150	158	162	168
Dmg	10	11	16	25	29	30	46	47	48	50
Bonus	2	2	3	5	6	6	9	9	10	10

Guard = what players attack; TN = what players defend against. **Roles** (Guard / HP / Dmg → typical BR / MR): Mook −1/×¼/×½ → T−5/T−3 · Soldier → T−3/**T** · Skirmisher +1/×¾ → T−3/T · Artillery ×¾/×¾, Area → T−3/T+1 · Controller ×½ + rider → T−4/T−2 · Brute −1/×2/×1½ → T−2/T+3 · Elite ×2, 2 attacks → T−2/T+3 · Heavy (Brute + Area, Engulf, Recharge, a horde penalty) → T+1/T+2 · Boss +1/×1 per PC/×PC÷4, Interrupt, Shift → T+1/T+4.
BR N = 1 of it is a fair fight for 4 level-N PCs · **MR N** = 4 of it are. **Fair:** win 90%+, someone Down 40–60%, death ≤5%, 3–7 rounds. Group Traits (Pack, Flanker +1 MR; Overwhelm, Crowd, Linked,

Frenzy, Leader +½ MR). Horde penalties (Bulky −4 MR, Territorial ≈ −1).
Budget (Hard = fair) = 1 unit per PC (2 PCs 1¾ · 3: 2¾ · 4: 4 · 5: 5½ · 6: 7). Easy ×½ · Standard ×¾ · Hard ×1 · Deadly ×1¼.
Units by rating − party level (−3/−2/−1/0/+1/+2/+3): group, by MR: ⅓ ½ ¾ **1** 1½ 2 3 · one centrepiece, by BR: 1½ 2 3 **4** 6 8 11. Next-stage creature ×2; previous-stage creature one step lower. Heavies vs 5+ PCs ×1½; Heavies on a grid ×1¼. Mutagenic/Purger: on a failed defense.

13. Character Building Guide

This chapter walks you from a blank sheet to a finished level 1 freelancer, then through both **Evolutions** to level 10. It tells you **what to pick and in what order**. The rules themselves live in chapters 1–8; when they disagree with this guide, they win.

Prefer clicking? The Character Builder (online) follows these steps, places your picks, checks legality, Evolves you at 4 and 7, and prints a sheet.

13.1 Everything on Your Sheet

Component	What it is	Step	Rules
Concept, Drive	Who you are, what you want	1, 11	Ch 2
Base Form	Juggernaut, Skitter, Oracle, Alembic or Siren: your stats, trees and Evolutions	2	Ch 2A
Stats	Grit, Moxie, Nerve, Gumption, Chutzpah	3	Ch 2
Origin	Background: 1 Knack + 1 Perk	4	Ch 2
Knacks	Narrow specialties; add Rank to checks	5	Ch 1
Augments	Your Form's 3 trees, Material (Bio/Chrome), nodes	6	Ch 3
Surges + Sequence	Your random combat powers	7	Ch 4
Signature Surges	Always-ready Surges (from level 4)	later	Ch 4
Gear + Scrip	Kit, weapons, armor, money, Upkeep	8	Ch 8
Derived numbers	Rank, HP, Armor, Speed, defenses, Flux Limit, attacks	9	Ch 2
Juice, trackers	Reward tokens; Flux, Death marks, Breathers, Last Gasp, Final Form	10	Ch 1, Ch 5
Scars, Faults, Injuries, Samples	Things that happen to you in play	later	Ch 5, Ch 6, Ch 7

13.2 Level 1, Step by Step

13.2.1 Concept

One sentence with a **job**, a **body change**, and a **flaw**: *"Ex-Ward electrician who wired her voice into the power grid and can't stop broadcasting."*

13.2.2 Base Form

Pick the Form that matches what you want to **do** in a fight:

You want to...	Form	Primary stat	Trees (primary / secondary / tertiary)
Hold the line, protect, hit hard up close	**Juggernaut**	Grit	Hide / Limbs / Glands
Be fast, slippery and deadly in melee	**Skitter**	Moxie	Wiring / Limbs / Senses
Shoot, spot, and bend luck	**Oracle**	Nerve	Senses / Mind / Wiring
Heal, poison, out-think	**Alembic**	Gumption	Glands / Hide / Mind
Talk, Taunt, control, lead	**Siren**	Chutzpah	Mind / Wiring / Limbs

13.2.3 Stats

Your Form sets **+3 / +2 / +1**. Put **+0** and **−1** in the two stats left over. Pick the −1 for the stat you'll be tested on least. A −1 in Grit costs 2 HP and a weak Endure; a −1 in Moxie means a weak Dodge (the most common defense); a −1 in Nerve means a weak Resist and a lower Flux Limit.

13.2.4 Origin

Roll d6 or choose. Write its **Knack** and **Perk**. Perks with numbers: *Corporate Washout* +100 Scrip; *Lab Escapee* +1 Surge known; *Clinic Rat* +Rank to Patch; *Ward Militia* +2 on group initiative.

13.2.5 Knacks

Your Origin gives one; write **two more** (3 total). Narrow and concrete: *Sewer Routes*, not *Survival*. You gain one more at levels 3, 6 and 9.

13.2.6 Augments

Take **6 nodes**, only from your Form's trees:

Tree	Nodes at level 1
Primary	Root + **2 Tier I**
Secondary	Root + **1 Tier I**
Tertiary	Root

For **each tree**, choose its **Material** (Bio or Chrome) when you take the Root:

You have	You are	Perk	Cost
Only Bio trees	**Bio**	Knit: +Rank HP per Bio tree after each fight and Breather	Bloom table
Only Chrome trees	**Chrome**	Firmware: swap one Primed Surge per fight	Glitch table, disadvantage vs Shock, **25 Scrip Upkeep per Chrome tree per mission**
Both	**Splice**	Knit (counting Bio trees) + Firmware (Chrome-tree parts) + roll both Overload tables, choose one	Chrome's costs above, **Flux Limit −1**

What each Root unlocks (your Surge parts, fixed by your Form): Hide → Pulse, Quake, Shell · Limbs → Wave, Snare · Senses → Glare, Veil · Glands → Burst, Toxin, Corrode, Mend · Wiring → Shock, Blaze, Haste · Mind → Dread, Link.

Three Roots give you a weapon-like attack: **Natural Weapons** (Limbs, d8 melee, Grit/Moxie), **Spit** (Glands, d8, 30 ft, Nerve/Gumption) and **Mind Spike** (Mind, d8, 60 ft, Nerve/Chutzpah).

13.2.7 Surges and the Sequence

Build **3 Surges** (4 for a Lab Escapee) and write them in Sequence slots **1–3**. Your **Sequence die is d4**, so slot **4 is Wild** (a Lab Escapee fills it). Prime is **2**.

The Surge recipe:

1. **Shape:** any base Shape (**Strike, Bolt, Infuse**) or one your Roots unlocked.
2. **Effect:** a **damage Effect** (base: **Kinetic**) for Strike/Bolt/Burst/Wave/Pulse, **or** an **Infuse Effect** for Infuse. Never mix. Every Form has at least two Infuse Effects.
3. **Attack stat:** the Shape's stat **or** the stat of the tree that unlocked the Effect (Hide Grit · Limbs Grit/Moxie · Senses Nerve · Glands Gumption · Wiring Moxie · Mind Chutzpah). This is how

every Form attacks with its primary stat.

4. **Twist** (optional): **one** at Rank 1–2, **two different** from Rank 3. Each must match the Shape (*Chain*: Strike/Bolt; *Linger*: area Shapes; *Leech*, *Overcharge*: damage only; *Sure*, *Reach*, *Hush*: any).
5. **Cost:** 1 Flux + 1 per Twist.
6. **Name it and describe it** in your Form's look.

Numbers on a Surge:

Shape	Attack	Damage
Strike (melee)	Grit or Moxie (or Effect's tree stat) + Rank	(Rank+1)d10 + stat
Bolt (60 ft)	Nerve (or Effect's tree stat) + Rank	(Rank+1)d8 + stat
Burst (10-ft radius, 60 ft)	Nerve (or Effect's tree stat) + Rank	(Rank+1)d6, no stat
Wave (15-ft cone / 30-ft line)	Grit or Nerve (or Effect's tree stat) + Rank	(Rank+1)d6, no stat
Pulse (10 ft around you)	Grit (or Effect's tree stat) + Rank	(Rank+1)d6, no stat
Infuse (you or an ally, 30 ft)	no roll	per Effect

Add **+1 die** for Kinetic and **+2 dice** for Overcharge. Burst and Wave hit allies in the area too.

A good first three: one **reliable damage** Surge in your primary stat, one **control** Surge (a rider that fits your trees), and one **Infuse** or **area** Surge for the team. Think ahead: at level 4 one Surge becomes your **always-ready Signature**, so the one you'd want every round is a good candidate.

13.2.8 Gear and Scrip

Take one **Starting Kit** (Ch 8). All include Light armor (Armor 1), GRAFT ID, radio, flashlight, 2 rations and 1 Damper. Then take **50 Scrip** (+100 Corporate Washout, +50 Face kit) and buy from Gear if you like.

- Weapons: **Damage = Rank × die + stat**; one Mod per weapon (100 Scrip). Natural Weapons can take a Mod; Spit and Mind Spike can't.
- You wear **one** armor (Light *or* Heavy), plus an optional Shield. **Armor max 4** (5 with Unbreakable, 6 for a Juggernaut with Siege Hide).
- **Upkeep:** 25 Scrip per Chrome tree (and per Smart-Link) each mission. GRAFT prepays 25 of your first mission's.

13.2.9 Fill In the Numbers

Number	Formula
Rank	⌈level ÷ 2⌉ (1 at level 1)
Max HP	12 + 2 × Grit + 5 × (level − 1); Hide *Thick* +2 × level
Armor	Light 1 / Heavy 2, Shield +1, *Plating* +1 (+2 from Rank 3), *Siege Hide* +1; max 4 (5 / 6)
Speed	30 ft (6 squares); +10 *Quickened*, +10 *Spring Legs*, −5 Heavy armor (+5 *Hollow Bones*)
Defenses	Dodge = Moxie + Rank · Endure = Grit + Rank · Resist = Nerve + Rank
Flux Limit	4 + Rank + Nerve, minimum 4; then −1 if Splice
Attack	stat + Rank; damage Rank × die + stat
Sequence / Prime / Juice	d4 / 2 / 1 (max 3)

13.2.10 Trackers

Mark the boxes you'll use in play: **Flux** (up to your Limit; going over is an Overload), **Death marks** (3), **Breathers** (2 per Lockdown), **Last Gasp** (1 per Lockdown), **Juice** (start each session with 1). Later: **Signature Surges** and **Final Form** (1 per Lockdown).

13.2.11 Drive

Answer: *Why did you take the Mutagen? What do you want before the campaign ends? Who in Halcyon do you owe, or hate?* Give the GM at least one name.

13.3 Leveling Up (1–10)

One mission = one level (Ch 7). Each level, in order:

1. **+5 Max HP** (+2 more with *Thick*).
2. **+1 primary-tree node** (always; you choose which) **and +1 node in your secondary or tertiary tree**. Gates: Tier II needs level 4 + 3 nodes in the tree; an Apex needs level 7 + 6 other nodes in the tree, and only in your primary or secondary tree. From level 9 the primary pick overflows into secondary/tertiary.
3. **+1 Surge** into the next empty slot. You may also **rewrite** one Surge, or rebuild one Signature.
4. **Optional respec:** swap one node for another of the same pick type that you qualify for.
5. **At levels 4 and 7, Evolve** (checklist below).
6. Recalculate Rank, HP, defenses, Limit, weapon dice.

Level	Rank	Stage	Nodes (prim + sec/tert + Evo)	Surges	Die	Wild	Prime	Signatures	Extra
1	1	Base	3 + 3	3	d4	1	2	—	3 Knacks
2	1	Base	4 + 4	4	d6	2	2	—	
3	2	Base	5 + 5	5	d6	1	2	—	+1 Knack
4	2	**Evo I**	6 + 6 + 1	6	**d8**	2	**3**	**1**	**Evolution I**; Tier II
5	3	Evo I	7 + 7 + 1	7	d8	1	3	1	2 Twists; Plating +2
6	3	Evo I	8 + 8 + 1	8	d8	0	3	1	+1 Knack
7	4	**Evo II**	9 + 9 + 2	9	**d12**	3	**4**	**2**	**Evolution II**; Apex
8	4	Evo II	10 + 10 + 2	10	d12	2	4	2	Primary full
9	5	Evo II	10 + 12 + 2	11	d12	1	4	2	+1 Knack; overflow
10	5	Final	10 + 14 + 2	12	d12	0	4	2	**Final Form**

13.3.1 The Evolution Checklist (levels 4 and 7)

1. **Stats:** Evo I → +5 / +3 / +2 / +1 / +0. Evo II → +8 / +4 / +3 / +2 / +1 (same order as your level 1 placement).
2. **Recalculate** HP (Grit changed), defenses, Flux Limit (Nerve changed), and every attack and Surge line.
3. **Prime** +1 (3, then 4). **Sequence die** up (d8, then d12): you'll have new Wild slots.
4. **Write your Form's Evolution node** into your primary tree (Ch 3).

5. **Build a Signature Surge** and write it in a Signature box. It's always Primed; once per round; normal Flux.
6. **Describe your new look** (your Form's stage table in Ch 2A), and plan your **Emergence** with the GM.

Final Form (level 10): once per Lockdown at the start of a combat: primary stat +2, Prime two extra, every Surge Amped.

- **Lab Escapee** has one fewer Wild slot (none at levels 6 and 10). It never adds Signatures.
- **In play** you may also gain: **Scars/Faults** from Overloads (some change numbers: *Hollow Bones, Drained Cell, Brittle Shell, Sticky Relay*), a **Blossom** Knack, *Patch Applied* (+1 Limit), **Injuries** until Lockdown, and **Samples** (a Surge spliced into a Wild slot for 100 Scrip; it may use the Boss's parts).
- **Scrip:** each mission pays 200 + 100 × level; pay Upkeep before the next one.

Planning tip: your primary tree fills by level 8 whatever you do, so the real choices are **order** (what you want before Evolution I) and **where your secondary/tertiary picks go**. Pour them into the secondary if you want its Apex at level 7–9 (you'll need 7 nodes there), or spread them for utility.

13.4 Builds by Form

Each Form can lean two ways. Each line suggests nodes for levels 1–4, a first Signature, and a kit.

Form	Build	Level 1 nodes (primary · secondary · tertiary)	Levels 2–4 (primary picks · sec/tert picks)	First Signature	Kit
Juggernaut	**Doorway** (tank)	Plating, Thick, Barbs · Natural Weapons, Extra Arm · Spit	Anchor, Shoulder Check, Menace · Spring Legs, Regenerate, Crusher Grip	*Floor Breaker* Pulse + Quake	Bruiser
Juggernaut	**Wrecker** (brawler)	Plating, Thick, Shoulder Check · Natural Weapons, Extra Arm · Spit	Barbs, Anchor, Adaptive · Spring Legs, Grapnel, Rend	*Piston Slam* Strike + Kinetic	Bruiser
Skitter	**Duelist**	Quickened, Capacitor, Reflex Spike · Natural Weapons, Extra Arm · Keen	Slipstream, Wall Run, Kinetic Battery · Lash Tail, Target Lock, Crusher Grip	*Live Wire* Strike + Shock	Sneak
Skitter	**Runner**	Quickened, Slipstream, Wall Run · Natural Weapons, Spring Legs · Keen	Capacitor, Reflex Spike, Afterimage · Grapnel, Extra Arm, Pounce	*Arc Lash* Wave + Shock	Wardrunner
Oracle	**Sniper**	Keen, Target Lock, Threat Sense · Uplink, Iron Will · Quickened	Analyzer, Echolocation, Long Sight · Read the Room, Intrude, Precog	*Ghost Line* Bolt + Kinetic + Hush	Gunhand
Oracle	**Spotter**	Keen, Analyzer, Threat Sense · Uplink, Intrude · Quickened	Target Lock, Echolocation, Weak Spot · Iron Will, Read the Room, Puppet	*Flashbulb* Bolt + Glare	Face
Alembic	**Medic**	Spit, Stim Gland, Antibodies · Plating, Thick · Uplink	Regenerate, Adrenal Dump, Spore Cloud · Barbs, Anchor, Living Wall	*Field Dressing* Infuse + Mend	Medic
Alembic	**Poisoner**	Spit, Regenerate, Stim Gland · Plating, Thick · Uplink	Adrenal Dump, Antibodies, Catalyst · Anchor, Intrude, Adaptive	*Acid Bloom* Burst + Corrode (Gumption)	Gunhand

Form	Build	Level 1 nodes (primary · secondary · tertiary)	Levels 2–4 (primary picks · sec/tert picks)	First Signature	Kit
Siren	**Commander**	Uplink, Commanding Voice, Iron Will · Quickened, Slipstream · Natural Weapons	Read the Room, Intrude, Puppet · Wall Run, Spring Legs, Afterimage	*Go, Go!* Infuse + Haste	Face
Siren	**Controller**	Uplink, Intrude, Commanding Voice · Quickened, Capacitor · Natural Weapons	Iron Will, Read the Room, Psychic Scream · Slipstream, Spring Legs, Overclock	*The Broadcast* Wave + Dread (Chutzpah)	Face

13.5 Common Mistakes

- **Taking a node outside your Form's trees.** You only have three.
- **Wrong split at level 1.** It's 3 primary / 2 secondary / 1 tertiary, Roots first.
- **Skipping the primary pick.** You get one every level until the tree is full (level 8), and must take it.
- **Tier II before level 4**, or with fewer than 3 nodes in that tree.
- **An Apex in your tertiary tree**, before level 7, or with fewer than 6 other nodes in the tree.
- **Choosing your Evolution node.** It's fixed by your Form and comes free at 4 and 7.
- **Forgetting to recalculate at an Evolution:** HP (Grit), Limit (Nerve), every attack and Surge line.
- **Writing a Signature on your Sequence.** It goes in its own box and doesn't count toward Surges known.
- **Using a part you haven't unlocked.** Only base parts (Strike, Bolt, Infuse, Kinetic) and your Roots' unlocks.
- **Infuse with a damage Effect**, or Bolt with Mend. Infuse only takes Infuse Effects.
- **Wrong Twist:** Chain on a Burst, Linger on a Bolt, Overcharge on Infuse, two Twists before Rank 3, the same Twist twice.
- **Adding the stat to area damage.** Burst, Wave and Pulse roll dice only.
- **Forgetting Splice −1 Limit** or **Chrome Upkeep** (and disadvantage vs Shock).
- **Armor over the cap,** or wearing Light and Heavy together.
- **Knowing too many Surges.** Surges known = level + 2 (Lab Escapee +1, Samples extra); the rest are Wild, on purpose.

13.6 Worked Example: Dree "Brownout" Ocampo (Siren)

13.6.1 Level 1 — Siren

1. **Concept:** Ex-Ward electrician who wired her voice into the power grid. She's a pirate-radio preacher of the blackout who can't stop broadcasting.
2. **Form: Siren** (Chutzpah primary; Mind / Wiring / Limbs).
3. **Stats:** Chutzpah +3, Moxie +2, Gumption +1 (set by the Form). She puts **Nerve +0**, **Grit −1** (she's skinny, but steady around live wires).
4. **Origin:** Ward Militia: *Squad Tactics*; +2 on group initiative, Brace as Quick once per combat.
5. **Knacks:** *Squad Tactics*, *Electrical Repair*, *Rooftop Routes*.
6. **Augments (6):**

- Mind (**Bio**): *Uplink* (Root), *Intrude*, *Commanding Voice*.
- Wiring (**Chrome**): *Quickened* (Root), *Slipstream*.
- Limbs (**Bio**): *Natural Weapons* (Root).

She has both Materials, so she is a **Splice**. Unlocked: Dread, Link, Shock, Blaze, Haste, Wave, Snare.

1. **Sequence (d4, Prime 2):**

#	Surge	Build	Flux	At level 1
1	Sizzle Line	Wave + Blaze (30-ft line; Moxie via Wiring)	1	+3 vs each Guard, 2d6 Blaze, Burning
2	Brownout	Bolt + Shock (Moxie via Wiring)	1	+3, 2d8+2 Shock, Dazed
3	Dead Air	Bolt + Dread (Chutzpah via Mind)	1	+4, 2d8+3 Psychic, Shaken
4	*Wild*			

Firmware can swap in *Sizzle Line* or *Brownout* (they use Blaze/Shock from her Chrome Wiring); *Dead Air* uses only Bio Mind parts, so it can't be swapped in.

1. **Gear:** Face kit (Concealed Pistol, Light melee, Hack deck, Flashbang, +50 Scrip) + common items. 100 Scrip; buys a Medkit (25), 75 left. Upkeep 25 for Wiring, prepaid for mission 1.
2. **Numbers:** Rank 1 · HP **10** · Armor **1** · Speed **40** · Dodge **+3**, Endure **+0**, Resist **+1** · Flux Limit **4** (4 + 1 + 0 = 5, −1 Splice) · Knit 2 · Juice 1. **Attacks:** Mind Spike +4, 1d8+3 Psychic (60 ft) · Claws +3, 1d8+2 · Knife +3, 1d6+2 · Pistol +1, 1d6. **Material:** Knit 2 HP (2 Bio trees × Rank 1); Firmware; Overload rolls both tables; disadvantage vs Shock.
3. **Drive:** She took the Mutagen to survive a substation fire. She wants the Ward's grid back on. She owes Scrapjack boss **Tallow** a new spine.

Playing her at level 1: her Limit of 4 is tiny, so two Surges and a Churn is an Overload. Lead with *Dead Air*, keep Commanding Voice (Quick Rally, +4 temporary HP to everyone) for the bad round, and stay behind the Juggernaut.

13.6.2 Level 4 — Evolution I: Diva

Level-ups: **2** *Iron Will* · *Wall Run* · Surge *Wire Up* (Infuse + Haste). **3** *Read the Room* · *Spring Legs* · Surge *Static Snare* (Wave + Snare) · Knack *Pirate Radio*. **4** *Psychic Scream* (Tier II) · *Overclock* (Tier II; Wiring has 3 nodes) · Surge *Overvolt* (Bolt + Shock + Overcharge) · **Evolution I**.

- **Look (Splice Diva):** iridescent skin and a frill of fins at the neck (Bio Mind); speaker grilles bloom along her collarbones and hum with mains current (Chrome Wiring).
- **Stats:** Chutzpah **+5**, Moxie +3, Gumption +2, Nerve +1, Grit +0. **Rank 2.**
- **Nodes (13):**
  - Mind (Bio): Uplink, Intrude, Commanding Voice, Iron Will, Read the Room, Psychic Scream, plus the Evolution node **Siren Song**.
  - Wiring (Chrome): Quickened, Slipstream, Wall Run, Overclock.
  - Limbs (Bio): Natural Weapons, Spring Legs.
- **Numbers:** HP **27** (12 + 0 + 15) · Armor 1 · Speed **50** · Dodge **+5**, Endure **+2**, Resist **+3** (advantage; can't be Shaken) · Flux Limit **6** (4 + 2 + 1 − 1) · Knit 4 · Prime **3** · Sequence **d8**.
- **Attacks:** Mind Spike +7, 2d8+5 Psychic · Claws +5, 2d8+3.
- **Signature Surge:** ***The Broadcast*** (Wave + Dread, Chutzpah): +7 vs each Guard in a 15-ft cone or 30-ft line, 3d6 Psychic, Shaken. 1 Flux, once per round, always ready.

- **Sequence (d8, Prime 3):**

#	Surge	Build	Flux	At level 4
1	Sizzle Line	Wave + Blaze	1	+5, 3d6, Burning (4/turn)
2	Brownout	Bolt + Shock	1	+5, 3d8+3, Dazed
3	Dead Air	Bolt + Dread	1	+7, 3d8+5, Shaken
4	Wire Up	Infuse + Haste	1	Ally takes a Move + Action, advantage
5	Static Snare	Wave + Snare (Moxie)	1	+5, 3d6, Held
6	Overvolt	Bolt + Shock + Overcharge	2	+5, 5d8+3, Dazed
7–8	*Wild*			

- **Emergence** (first fight of mission 4): she gains 8 temporary HP, every enemy within 30 ft is Shaken, and her first *Broadcast* costs 0 Flux.
- *What changed:* her primary attack went from +4 to **+7** against a T4 Guard of 14 (a 70% hit chance; at level 3 she had +5 against Guard 14, 60%). She can Surge every round, and Siren Song sends whole rooms at Rook. Her Limit of 6 is still her weak point. Every turn she Surges costs 1 Flux, so Surging every turn Overloads her partway through the second fight before a Breather. Mix in Mind Spike turns.

13.6.3 Level 7 — Evolution II: Choir

Level-ups: **5** *Puppet* · *Afterimage* · Surge *Crowd Surge* (Infuse + Link + Sure). **6** *Glamour* · *Grapnel* · Surge *Arc Halo* (Wave + Shock + Reach) · Knack *Crowd Work*. **7 Apex *Hive Mind*** (level 7, and 8 other Mind nodes) · *Arc Jump* · Surge *Blackout* (Bolt + Dread + Chain + Overcharge) · **Evolution II**.

- **Look (Splice Choir):** a crown of soft horns and a dozen small mouths singing along her arms (Bio); an antenna crown and a cape of fibre-optic cable that broadcasts on every frequency (Chrome).
- **Stats:** Chutzpah **+8**, Moxie +4, Gumption +3, Nerve +2, Grit +1. **Rank 4.**
- **Nodes (20):**
  - Mind (Bio): Uplink, Intrude, Commanding Voice, Iron Will, Read the Room, Psychic Scream, Puppet, Glamour, **Hive Mind**, plus **Siren Song** and **Crown of Will**.
  - Wiring (Chrome): Quickened, Slipstream, Wall Run, Overclock, Afterimage, Arc Jump.
  - Limbs (Bio): Natural Weapons, Spring Legs, Grapnel.
- **Numbers:** HP **44** (12 + 2 + 30) · Armor 1 · Speed 50 · Dodge **+8**, Endure **+5**, Resist **+6** · Flux Limit **9** (4 + 4 + 2 − 1) · Knit 8 · Prime **4** · Sequence **d12** (9 Surges + 3 Wild).
- **Attacks:** Mind Spike +12, 4d8+8 Psychic · Claws +8, 4d8+4.
- **Signature Surges (2):** *The Broadcast*, now +12, 5d6 Psychic, Shaken, and ***Live Feed*** (Infuse + Haste): every round, an ally takes a Move and an Action with advantage. Each costs 1 Flux, once per round. She can't use both in one turn (one Action), unless *Overclock* gives her a second Action.
- **New Sequence entries:** 7 *Crowd Surge* (2 Flux: target + 4 allies + 1 extra get advantage on their next roll) · 8 *Arc Halo* (2 Flux: +8, 5d6 Shock, Dazed, 30-ft cone or 60-ft line) · 9 *Blackout* (3 Flux: +12, 7d8+8 Psychic, Shaken, then half damage to a second target within 15 ft) · 10–12 *Wild*.

- *What changed:* +12 against a T7 Guard of 17 is an **80%** hit. *Crown of Will* turns the enemy's best Soldier into hers for the fight. *Hive Mind* lets an ally borrow her +8 Chutzpah for one roll a round, and gives one ally an extra Prime. She is the party's engine now, but with Dodge +8 against TN 16 she still fails 35% of the time. She stays out of reach and lets Siren Song point the room at the tank.

14. Appendix: Arcade vs Tabletop

The arcade (*Gauntlet mode*) plays these rules on a battle map, with the computer running the enemies. Almost everything it does is the tabletop rule, read on a grid (Positioning). This appendix lists what it does **differently**, so nobody mistakes a video-game setting for a rule. When the two disagree, **this book wins**.

The full audit (every mechanic checked against the engine and the simulators, 2026-10-29) is in `Current_Work.md`, *Rules Audit*.

14.1 Difficulty Settings (not rules)

- **Party size is the difficulty.** Easy, Medium and Hard field 5, 4 and 3 freelancers.
- **Threat factors.** On top of the book's Hard budget, the arcade multiplies minion budgets and Boss HP by ×1.0 / ×1.22 / ×1.38 (Boss damage by half of that), ramping in over levels 1–3. These are tuned so a whole 20-fight run is winnable but not certain. Use the book's budgets at the table (Threats).
- **Mercy.** In standard mode a lost fight can be retried from its start; each retry takes 6% off the enemies' HP and 4% off their damage. There's no tabletop equivalent: at the table, a lost fight is a story event (Going Down).
- **GRAFT recovery.** In standard mode a freelancer who dies comes back at the next Lockdown with a permanent Scar or Fault. **Permadeath** mode plays death straight.
- **Fixed rhythm.** Every level is a minion fight, a Breather, a Boss (or centrepiece) fight, a level-up and a Lockdown. Minion fights use one or two creature types from one faction (at most 8 creatures); levels without one of the three Bosses use the closest-rated Elite, Brute, Controller, Artillery or Soldier, scaled like a Boss.

14.2 Automation (the computer plays a part for you)

- **Auto-play** ("Auto this turn", "Auto: rest of round", "Auto-battle") is a computer player. It is not a rule and it's not optimal.
- **Reactions fire on their own** when they help: Bulwark, Threat Sense, Precog (only for big hits), Unbreakable, Reflex Spike, Fortress, Omen, Deadeye, Hair Trigger, Opportunity Strikes. At the table you declare them.
- **Last Gasp** fires automatically the first time you would drop to 0 HP each Lockdown. At the table it's your choice.
- **Choices made for you:** a Splice's Overload keeps the better of the two tables; Bloom Lore rerolls bad results; Hive Mind gives its extra Prime to the ally with the fewest; Puppet picks its own target; Perfect Expression and Echo take the best Surges; Red Mist attacks the nearest creature; the primary node at level-up is picked automatically.
- **Enemy tactics** are a fixed AI (Running the Game lists the same tendencies as GM defaults). If nobody has been hurt for three rounds, the auto-player stops playing safe and walks in, so fights can't stall.

14.3 Information

- **Enemy stats are visible** (Guard, TN, HP, attacks, ratings). At the table you learn them with Analyze; in the arcade Analyze still matters for Exposed and Weak Spot.
- Dice resolve at once, so there's **no Juice reroll** of a d20. Juice can still set a Sequence die and Shrug a condition.

14.4 Simplifications

- **Initiative** is always the Moxie group check (no ambushes or surprise rounds).
- **Haste** gives the ally one immediate Action (not Unleash) with advantage, but no Move.
- **Mitosis** makes one weapon attack at the end of each of your turns and is destroyed by a failed Dodge (35% of the attacks aimed at you go for it).
- **Scars, Faults and injuries** gained in a fight apply from the next fight.
- **Grapple / Shove** offer Held or Prone (no push).
- **Not modelled:** cover, difficult terrain, elevation, Shaken's "can't move closer", Swarms sharing a square, Spore Cloud's "against attacks from outside" (it just Veils), and these node features: Adaptive, Arc Jump, Wall Run, Many Hands' second grab and Extra Arm's Push. Out-of-combat features (Read the Room, Keen, Uplink's mind-speech, Knacks) have nothing to do in a fight-only game.
- **Every creature fills one square**, Huge ones included.

14.5 The Simulators Behind the Ratings

The Boss and Minion Ratings in Threats come from `tools/encounter_sim.py`, which plays **without a map**. It abstracts positioning: an enemy Area catches each other freelancer with a fixed chance (30% / 45% / 65% for small / medium / large Areas), 15% of freelancer turns and 10% of enemy actions are spent moving instead of attacking, a Held melee enemy loses half its actions, and Fortress's Area halving is applied half the time. Those are modelling choices for theatre-of-the-mind play, not rules. Checked against the grid (`tools/grid_budget.js`), the budgets hold on a map except for Heavies, which cost ×1¼ on a grid (Threats §7).

15. Glossary

Every game term in one place, A to Z, with where its full rule lives.

Term	Meaning	Rule
Action	The main thing you do on your turn (Attack, Unleash, Dash, Brace, Help, Patch, Analyze, Taunt, Rally, Grapple, Shove…)	Actions
Advantage / Disadvantage	Roll 2d20, keep the higher / lower. They don't stack; both cancel	Core Rules
Amped	A Primed Surge rolled as doubles (or made so by Emergence or Final Form): it costs 0 Flux	Priming
Analyze	Gumption action on a creature you can see within 60 ft: learn its stats, and it's Exposed	Actions
Apex	A tree's capstone node: level 7+, 6 other nodes in the tree, primary or secondary tree only	How Trees Work
Area / Single	Attack types. An Area still deals half damage on a miss or a successful defense	Attacking, Areas
Armor	Flat reduction to each hit (minimum 1 damage); max 4 (5 with Unbreakable, 6 with Siege Hide)	Damage, Armor
Augment / Node / Root / Tree	Your skill-tree abilities. A Root opens a tree; each tree has 10 standard nodes	Augment Trees
Base Form	One of five body plans (Juggernaut, Skitter, Oracle, Alembic, Siren): sets your stats and your primary, secondary and tertiary trees	Base Forms
Bio / Chrome / Splice	A tree's **Material**: grown or installed. A Splice has both	Material
Bloom / Glitch	The Overload tables for Bio / Chrome	Overload
Boss	A centrepiece enemy: sheds a condition at the start of its turn, gets one Interrupt per round	Role
Boss Rating (BR) / Minion Rating (MR)	The party level at which one creature (BR) or a group worth 1 unit each (MR) is a fair fight for 4 rested freelancers	Ratings
Brace	Action: defenses with advantage until your next turn	Actions
Breather / Lockdown	Short rest (half Max HP, Flux 0, two per Lockdown) / full rest (everything resets)	Rest
Budget / Units	Encounter currency: a Hard (fair) fight is 1 unit per freelancer; each creature's units come from its rating minus the party level	Building an Encounter
Churn	Quick action: +1 Flux, roll your Sequence die once more. Not on a turn you Unleash	Churning
Close / Near / Far / Distant	Theatre-of-the-mind distances (5 / 30 / 120 ft / beyond)	Positioning
Conditions	Blinded, Burning, Dazed, Exposed, Held, Poisoned, Prone, Shaken, Veiled; most last until the end of the affected creature's next turn	Conditions
Crit	A natural 20 on an attack: roll the damage dice twice	Natural 20s
Death mark	Gained while Down; 3 means dead	Going Down
Defenses	Dodge (Moxie), Endure (Grit), Resist (Nerve), each + Rank. Players roll them against an enemy's TN	Defending
Down	At 0 HP: you can't act, you roll to stabilise, damage gives death marks	Going Down
Effect / Shape / Twist	The parts you build a Surge from	Building a Surge

Term	Meaning	Rule
Emergence	The on-screen moment of an Evolution: temp HP 2 × level, enemies within 30 ft who see it are Shaken, first Signature use Amped	Emergence
Engulf	A Heavy's Area deals extra damage for each freelancer caught beyond the first	Traits
Enemy Phase / Player Phase	The two halves of a round: freelancers act in any order, then the enemies act one by one	The Round
Evolution (I / II)	The metamorphosis at level 4 / 7: new stats, +1 Prime, a bigger Sequence die, an Evolution node, a Signature Surge, a new look	What an Evolution Gives
Exposed	A condition: −2 Guard (enemies) or −2 to defense rolls (freelancers)	Conditions
Fair fight	Won ≥ 90% of the time, someone Down 40–60%, a death ≤ 5%, 3–7 rounds (a Hard fight)	Ratings
Final Form	Level 10: once per Lockdown, +2 primary stat, two extra Primes, every Surge Amped for a fight	Final Form
Firmware / Knit	The Chrome / Bio Material perks (swap a Surge / heal after fights)	Material
Flux / Flux Limit	Instability from Surges; Limit = 4 + Rank + Nerve. Going over it is an Overload	Flux
GRAFT	The contractor that hires the freelancers	The Setting
Grid	Playing on a battle map: 1 square = 5 ft, diagonals count 1	On a Grid
Guard	The number freelancers attack against	Threat Level
Heavy / Pack	Enemy kinds: a Heavy has a big Area attack (costs ×1¼ units on a grid); a Pack enemy has group Traits	Role, Building an Encounter
Injury	Temporary harm when you get up from Down (d6)	Injury Table
Interrupt	A Boss's one extra action (no Move) after any freelancer's turn, once per round	The Round
Juice	Reward token (max 3): reroll a d20, choose a Prime, or Shrug a condition	Juice
Knack	A narrow specialty; add Rank to checks that use it	Knacks
Last Gasp	Once per Lockdown, when you'd drop to 0 HP: Overload on purpose instead and stay at 1 HP	Last Gasp
Line of sight	A clear line from you to the target; walls block it, creatures don't	Ranges
Long range	Up to twice a ranged weapon's range, at disadvantage. Not for Areas, grenades or Surges	Ranges
Mook	The weakest enemy Role: a quarter of the HP, half the damage, fielded in numbers	Role
Move / Dash / Move carefully	Your speed in feet each turn (split freely) / an Action for a second Move / half speed without provoking	Your Turn, Opportunity Strikes
Mutagenic X	Enemy Trait: you gain X Flux when you fail your defense against its attack	Mutagenic Threats
Opportunity Strike	A melee attack (using your Reaction) when an enemy leaves your reach; enemies get one per round each	Opportunity Strikes
Origin	Your background: a Knack and a Perk	Origins
Overload	Going over your Flux Limit: damage, a table roll, Flux back to 0	Overload
Prime / Primed	How many Surges you roll ready at the start of a fight (2; 3 from L4; 4 from L7), and a Surge that's ready	Priming

Term	Meaning	Rule
Primary / Secondary / Tertiary	Your Form's three best stats (+3/+2/+1) and its three trees	Base Forms
Push	Gain 1 Flux for a node's extra effect	How Trees Work
Quick action	A small extra on your turn (draw, stim, Churn, Target Lock, talk)	Quick Actions
Rank	⌈level ÷ 2⌉ (1–5): added to attacks, defenses and Knack checks; multiplies weapon dice	The Roll
Reaction	One per round, on anyone's turn: Opportunity Strikes and Reaction nodes	Reactions
Reach	The squares next to you (5 ft); some nodes and creatures reach 10 ft	Opportunity Strikes
Role / Trait / T	The parts of a threat: its Threat level, its Role and its Traits	Threats
Sample	A harvested Boss or Elite part, spliced in as a Surge	Samples
Scar / Fault	Permanent Bio / Chrome Overload quirk	Scars and Faults
Scrip	Money	Gear
Sequence / Sequence die	Your numbered Surge list, rolled with a d4 / d6 / d8 / d12; empty slots are Wild	The Sequence
Signature Surge	Always ready (once per round), one per Evolution; not on the Sequence	Signature Surges
Spill / Spill Clock	The disaster that made Halcyon / the GM's six-segment mission timer	The Setting, The Spill Clock
Stage	Base, Evolution I, Evolution II, Final	Stages
Stats	Grit, Moxie, Nerve, Gumption, Chutzpah; set by Form and stage	The Five Stats
Surge / Unleash	A random combat power / the Action that uses one	Surges
Theatre of the mind	Playing without a map, using the four distance bands	Positioning
Tier I / Tier II	Node tiers: Tier I needs the Root; Tier II needs level 4+ and 3 nodes in the tree	How Trees Work
TN (Threat Number)	The number freelancers defend against	Threat Level
Upkeep	25 Scrip per Chrome tree per mission	Material
Wait	Take your turn later in the Player Phase	The Round
Wild / Wild Surge	An empty Sequence slot; roll on the d12 Wild table	Wild Surge Table